The World's Most Dangerous Morning Show

Political Meaning in Black Entertainment Media

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Draft for committee review · October 2026 · Please do not circulate

Abstract

How does a Black entertainment outlet produce political meaning, and what shifts it? Black Americans consume a higher proportion of comedy and talk podcasts relative to straightforward news podcasts than other groups, and are also more likely to get their news from podcasts. Political communication research traditionally centers mainstream, "hard" news platforms, and their growing work on politics embedded within entertainment media has not yet reached Black media or the tradition it lives in where both advocacy and entertainment have always been intersected. In contrast, scholarship centering the Black counterpublic theorizes these venues without measuring them. I study *The Breakfast Club*, a Black-hosted morning show distributed as syndicated radio, a billion-download podcast, and streaming video, using a census of 131 political elite appearances and a computational content analysis of 5,518 episodes. Analysis of the corpus introduces an important distinction in how politics is framed within entertainment media as opposed to traditional mainstream political media: I distinguish direct framing, where political claims are explicitly stated as such, from ambient framing, in which political meaning is carried through the tone and selection of ostensibly cultural content. Direct framing rises consistently within the windows of presidential elections and the George Floyd protests (but not with midterms or the *Dobbs* decision), and politicians arrive in the direct lead-up to presidential elections and bring it with them. Ambient framing, in contrast, is stable across seven years and varies instead with the show's own segment formats. Most political content in both registers occurs with no politician present, and coding by topic alone would capture fewer than half of it. The findings extend counterpublic theory to commercial audio and show that a founding feature of the Black press now reaches audiences through channels the discipline's instruments were not built to see.

I. Introduction

> "You got more questions? I tell you what, if you have a problem figuring out whether you're for me or Trump, then you ain't black."
>
> Joe Biden, in a 2020 interview with *The Breakfast Club*

On May 22, 2020, Joe Biden appeared on *The Breakfast Club*, a syndicated hip-hop morning show, and said the line above, which dominated the news cycle for days to come (Memoli and Sotomayor 2020). The presumptive presidential nominee, in the middle of a pandemic-constrained campaign, was not the first politician to make headlines with a gaffe in this forum, joining the likes of his running mate Kamala Harris's ill-received admission of prior marijuana

use during a 2019 primary campaign stop at the outlet, and Hillary Clinton's infamous quote about keeping "hot sauce" in her purse on the platform in 2016 (Nicks 2016; Bryant 2019). All three interviews provoked controversy about how political hopefuls attempt to engage Black voters, and about the authenticity of their commitment. But how did Democratic presidential hopefuls end up on a hip-hop radio program in the first place, engaging in political talk with a DJ, a comedian, and a gossip columnist on a program more widely known for its forays into celebrity feuds, new music, and even relationship advice?

These are the best-known visits among many. Between 2015 and 2026, political elites appeared on the show 131 times: seventy-six candidates, officeholders, and former officials, including a former President, a future President, a sitting Vice President, most of the 2020 Democratic presidential primary field, and, beginning with the 2024 cycle, a run of Republican candidates. While these events have generated extensive news coverage and follow-up opinion pieces as campaign stops, few have treated them as data and stepped back to examine how an entertainment media platform can function as a political institution, particularly for Black voters.

This paper is motivated by a question that is much larger than this one show: What is the ideological landscape of Black media in the new media era, and how would we know? Black Americans get news from podcasts at higher rates than other groups, are more likely to hear news discussed on podcasts, and are more likely to say they listen to podcasts to keep up with current events (Shearer 2023). Black podcast listeners are more likely than White or Hispanic listeners to hear news discussed on podcasts, at 76 percent against 67 and 64 percent, and more likely to listen in order to keep up with current events, at 40 percent against 28 percent. The outlets they turn to are entertainment outlets: the topics Black listeners choose most are entertainment and pop culture, relationships, comedy, and money, and the shows at the top of the Black podcast audience are comedy and hip-hop talk shows, not news programs (Edison Research 2024). Political communication research has no established way to measure the political content of such outlets, because its measures were built for outlets that label their politics. Black politics research has theorized the informal venues where Black political attitudes are formed but has rarely measured what is said in them. This paper seeks to chart this unmapped landscape and to inspire subsequent works to expand our tools and vocabulary for measuring political information within the media.

The case selection also emphasizes two understudied aspects of the new media era within political science and communication: radio and podcasts, and Black-oriented and Black-led platforms. Political communication scholarship engaging radio and podcasting is small but growing in the discipline, and most assessments of the role of Black media emphasize the historic advocacy of the Black press, the role of newspapers, Black journalists at white publications, or focusing on the Civil Rights Movement and Black media prior to the 21st century (Squires 2000; Bedingfield 2023).

Furthermore, new media blurs format and reach. *The Breakfast Club* is a nationally syndicated radio show, a podcast, and a YouTube channel; it was simulcast on Revolt from 2014 to 2021, has aired as a daily edition on BET and VH1 since 2023, and has streamed on Netflix since January 2026. The case selection emphasizes the historical gaps filled by placing a lens upon Black radio and podcasts, and is further bolstered by the atypical nature of its vast reach and scale, reaching a Black audience through every channel the new media era offers.

This paper seeks to examine *The Breakfast Club* as a political institution, and maps its politics through appearances by political elites and its textual spoken content. The first is addressed through a census of political elites who appear across the course of the show's run, and coded by the timing of these appearances relative to elections and partisanship. The data establishes that the appearances are systematic and not incidental in nature. The latter is examined through a computational content analysis, spanning 5,518 episodes and roughly 180,000 segments (chunks) of text. The text was coded for topic, for the presence of political framing, and for ideological position. In conjunction, these two components emphasize the political utility of this venue for elites, the span of the political work the venue encompasses, and, through exploiting the variation of national events and the show's format, what actually is moving and shifting the register of its political discussion

I argue that Black audio media like *The Breakfast Club* primarily carries political meaning through what I call ambient framing: political meaning embedded in the tone, emphasis, and selection of cultural content rather than explicitly stated as politics. Direct framing, meaning explicit political content where political claims and positions are stated as such, is distinguished from ambient framing, where political meaning is imbued and carried through tone and selection of cultural content. In practice, a passage is coded as direct framing when it takes a clear position on a policy or systemic issue, when policing, race, or the criminal justice system are discussed as a civil rights matter, or when politicians or an election's stakes are engaged, and as ambient framing when its tone, emphasis, or selection of content invokes racialized policing, systemic injustice, or group-based political meaning without directly stating it. What separates the two is whether a position is stated, not whether race or policing is the subject.

From this descriptive analysis, I find that this ambient framing is the baseline register of the show, and holds at a consistent level in a narrow band spanning seven years from 2019 to 2026. In contrast, the show experiences spikes in the amount of direct political content in response to national events like presidential elections and the 2020 protests in response to the murder of George Floyd. These are what Cathy Cohen calls consensus issues, events Black institutions treat as bearing on the community as a whole, as opposed to cross-cutting issues like the Dobbs decision, which divide the community's institutions rather than mobilizing them (Cohen 1999). In the final month leading up to a presidential election, political elites show up at more than double the show's ordinary rate, 2.4 times, within 30 days, and not before midterms. Even so, these elite appearances only account for about 10.4 percent of the show's direct political content and 2.6 percent of its ambient content, meaning that the majority of the show's political content comes from the show's regular hosts and content. Ambient framing is more concentrated in formats where there is more individual commentary as opposed to regular ensemble shows when holding topic and year constant. The issue also appears to shape the register: policing and abortion arrive on the show framed as direct politics, while sexuality is primarily discussed as celebrity gossip and, when it is framed politically at all, far more often in an ambient frame.

I aim for this analysis to expand and extend our conception of the Black counterpublic to include commercial audio platforms that now bear the historical function of Black legacy media and cultural spaces and have inherited the everyday-talk function. I also contribute a novel measurement of an everyday-talk venue at scale rather than simply theorizing it. I argue the entertainment-effects framework in political communication requires modification for a

Black media tradition that never separated the political from the entertaining, and establishes a corpus and a measurement strategy to inspire subsequent works interrogating these issues.

The paper begins by situating the study at the nexus of the literatures examining radio as political communication, the history of the Black counterpublic and everyday talk, and the emergent literature in political science examining the political implications of entertainment media (Section II). I follow with a brief history of *The Breakfast Club* as a platform and the scale of its reach as a new media platform (Section III). Section IV sketches out the complete transcript corpus, outlining the full content analysis, the classification pipeline, examples of what the two registers look like in the transcript, and data limitations. Subsequently, Section V reports the census of political elite appearances on *The Breakfast Club,* and their connection to the show's content. Section VI presents the results: how the show's composition has changed, where each register lives, and what moves each of them. Section VII discusses what the paper establishes, what it does not, and what follows.

II. Why Black Talk Radio?: Three Literatures and the Gap Between Them

This structural analysis of *The Breakfast Club* spans the gaps left across three distinct literatures in political communication, Black politics, and political exposure from entertainment media. Scholars in communication studies have produced expansive and convincing literature on the causal impact of radio and audio media, little of which addresses Black audiences or analyzing Black-oriented media outlets. Black politics scholars have extensively outlined theoretically the Black counterpublic and the political importance of "everyday talk" on political discourse; however, concrete measurement of its impact, and literal analysis of what is said in these spaces is thin, and there is a significant gap in the historical record particularly when attempting to map these concepts onto Black media institutions of today and the new media environment. Finally, there is a rapidly growing literature on unintended or incidental political effects of entertainment media on attitudes. These analyses, while informative and certainly relevant to this project, analytically draw a strict barrier between political and entertainment media in a way which does not engage or carry effectively to Black media platforms. The following literature review addresses each of these areas and names where *The Breakfast Club* sits at a critical nexus and gap within all three.

Radio and the Politics of Audio

Analysis about the linkage between radio and political behavior is more extensive in economics rather than political science. Radio has been linked to both concrete policy implementation shifts such as the expansion of New Deal relief in the 1930s as well as ideological and behavior effects such as lower support for sitting Presidents, increases in support and registration for local parties, and gains in party support amongst partisans from radio propaganda (Strömberg 2004; Yanagizawa-Drott 2014; Adena et al. 2015; Wang 2021). The same design has been applied to partisan cable news, where the spread of Fox News has been linked to shifts in vote share (DellaVigna and Kaplan 2007).

Talk radio makes up a smaller subset of political science literature, the majority of which is encompassed by analysis of conservative talk radio. Conservative talk radio, epitomized by pundits such as Rush Limbaugh, emphasize talk radio's capacity for persuading and polarizing listeners, and establish the host as functionally opinion leaders and audiences as discerning

consumers who self-select into content that confirms existing biases and turn the station otherwise (Barker 2002; Jamieson and Cappella 2008). While its acknowledgement of the idiosyncratic nature of the radio media and the power of opinion leadership is certainly germane to the power of radio that this work engages, it still focuses on a small band of direct, explicitly political radio as politically consequential.

A rapidly growing contingent of scholarship surrounding podcasting, the descendant and medium of the aforementioned traditional radio, extends personalized politics to millions of podcast listeners: mapping the trajectories of guests bouncing across the expansive network of political podcasts, and the place of podcasts in the conservative identity politics of the 2024 election (Bratcher 2022; DeMets and Spiro 2025; Warner et al. 2026). The closest work to this paper involves recent research on code-switching on podcasts by political candidates to reach the niche audiences that podcasts engage, and how cultural agents reshape political communication, which together make elite appearances on entertainment venues an object of political communication research in their own right (Bratcher and Cabosky 2024; Kim and York 2026).

Across both the traditional radio effects literature and newer forays into podcasting, Black radio remains either a clear omission or only receives a cursory address. Historic work emphasizes the importance of the rise of Black-formatted radio stations in the 1920s as a medium for organizing for Black civil rights and civic opportunity, and operating as a critical element of the Black public sphere during the Jim Crow era (Barlow 1999). The most direct ancestor of this paper is from Catherine Squires' work documenting an African American-owned talk radio station in Chicago, finding that listeners engaged with the radio station as a prominent public forum for both classic political concerns as well as broader identity politics; particularly, even in the face of the pessimistic account of commercial media's role in contributing to the decline of the public sphere, WVON-AM remained an integral political institution and place of political discourse for Black Chicagoans (Squires 2000). The study attributes the loyalty (and sustaining financial support when advertising revenue fell) of the audience to the station's Black ownership and cultivation of a space where Black listeners felt they had the ability to talk their "talk" (Squires 2000, 85). Squires' work, while certainly foundational, is now a quarter century old, focuses only on local urban radio, and is still one of very few studies to treat Black audio as a political institution. Very little work has engaged the expanse of nationally syndicated Black morning shows like *The Breakfast Club* as political institutions in their own right.

The radio-podcast politics literature has not done enough to engage the implications that Black-led and hosted venues have for Black listeners. While much of the data engaging the demographic breakdown of listeners is proprietary, public opinion surveys have found that Black podcast listeners are more likely than other listeners to hear news discussed on podcasts and to listen to keep up with current events (Shearer 2023). Furthermore, while over half of Black podcast listeners surveyed say that the race of the hosts they listen to is important to them, only about a fifth of the hosts of the most popular podcasts come from underrepresented racial or ethnic groups, which makes the few Black-hosted shows at the top of the rankings disproportionately important as venues for that audience (Edison Research 2023, 2024; Annenberg Inclusion Initiative 2025).

Everyday Talk and the Black Counterpublic

In his seminal work on the public sphere, Jürgen Habermas centralizes in its definition the ability of citizens, in a space separate from the state, to engage in rational-critical debate as equals and so to shape public opinion (Habermas 1989). Numerous works in Black politics have since noted that systematic exclusion from the institutions that make up this public sphere has created parallel structures of discourse, collectively known as counterpublics (Dawson 2001; Squires 2002; Brooks 2005; Graham and Smith 2016; Bedingfield 2023). In political science particularly, Dawson theorizes the Black counterpublic as a primary and influential discursive infrastructure through which distinct Black political ideologies developed, and shows that this infrastructure persists even as formal exclusion declines (Dawson 2001).

Further complicating this conceptualization of the Black public sphere, Squires offers a vocabulary which moves beyond the framework of a single counterpublic to include marginal publics, distinguished by their relationship to dominant publics and the limited resources they have available (Squires 2002). While counterpublics exist to carry discourse into wider arenas in the constant contest to the dominant narratives of the public sphere, enclave publics conduct their discussion out of the sight of the mainstream (often involuntarily) and satellite publics maintain a deliberately separate discursive space that does not seek integration with the mainstream (Squires 2002). By grounding these definitions in resources and conditions as opposed to identity, one particular Black public sphere can move amongst these modes and evolve in response to context and circumstances. The mobility of Squires' typology is central to this present paper: a nationally syndicated show and podcast like *The Breakfast Club* which addresses a Black audience in their vernacular, hosts presidential and political candidates surrounding a campaign, and has an extensive cross-platform reach that likely includes non-Black listeners can exist across these modes in the span of one morning or episode.

The Black counterpublic is a conundrum: capacious and varied in its functions, yet occupying a limited space where different spheres hold joint functions and boundaries are less clear. Where white Americans were historically given the space to hold political office, control the media, and exercise hegemonic control of institutions, Black Americans forged these institutions from the residuals, building their own class of leadership, press, and forums for life. Black political life was forged in its social nature, with leaders who came from churches, business, the academy, and ultimately, whether through their visibility or their economic status, culture and celebrity. The result is a conceptual blurring that muddles the traditional bifurcation of media: Black popular media is Black political media.

The most prominent work to extend the counterpublic framework from elite discourse to the community level is from Melissa Harris-Perry's *Barbershops, Bibles, and BET*, arguing that Black political thought forms substantially through everyday talk in barbershops, churches, and Black media, and that political science has neglected these venues by centering formal institutions (Harris-Lacewell 2004). Her expansive theory allows routine conversations and informal interactions to form important foundations of political identity and engagement beyond the ballot box and formal policy debates.[1] This intervention is a direct ancestor of this project, although the venues she identified have changed since she wrote, as church attendance among younger Black Americans, particularly Gen Z, has declined (McGrady and Lee 2024).

1 Harris-Perry's 2004 book was published under the name Harris-Lacewell.

Barbershops declined by 23 percent nationally between 1992 and 2012 as men's grooming shifted toward upscale salons, although the neighborhood barbershop has remained central in Black communities (Barber 2016). BET canceled its nightly newscast in 2005 in favor of hourly news briefs, several years after its sale to Viacom, and fell from the most-watched cable network among Black viewers in 2010 to sixth by 2017 and forty-third among all cable networks in 2024 (Associated Press 2005; Paskin 2005; BET Networks 2010; Katz 2018; Schneider 2024). The mechanism as described, however, in which political reasoning is embedded in cultural life rather than segregated from it, has not disappeared but rather migrated to platforms like the focus of this study.

Particularly relevant to the machinery of this project as it relates to Black media's discussion of Black issues is Cathy Cohen's groundbreaking work, *The Boundaries of Blackness* (Cohen 1999). In it, Cohen provides the language of consensus issues, those that Black political elites and institutions frame as affecting the group as a whole and as bearing on its collective standing, and cross-cutting issues, which, by contrast, disproportionately affect a subgroup of the community, particularly a subgroup already marginalized within it by class, gender, sexuality, or perceived moral standing (Cohen 1999).

Cohen connects this dichotomy of issues to a broader issue of secondary marginalization, where dominant members and institutions of a marginalized group police which issues (and which members) count as legitimate concerns of the group, often in the name of respectability and the group's standing before a white public (Cohen 1999). While Cohen primarily applies this to churches and civil rights organizations, she also extends this to the Black press. The main source of the paper's variation, consensus and cross-cutting shocks, applies Cohen's theory to how a Black-led radio show may decide what and what not to say, and how they frame issues that are traditional or mainstream issues for the Black community versus issues that affect more marginalized segments of Black listeners (Cohen 1999). A show whose direct register responds to consensus shocks and not to cross-cutting ones would display Cohen's mechanism in its content rather than in institutional outcomes, which is the second expectation stated below.

Neither work has systematically coded what is said in an everyday talk venue over time and at scale (Cohen 1999; Harris-Lacewell 2004). The gap is partly a function of the venues themselves: *The Breakfast Club* leaves a transcript and record that simply cannot exist at that level of the numerous conversations between the church pews and barbershops of the nation.

Entertainment Media and Political Attitudes

There is emergent scholarship surrounding incidental political exposure and attitude shift from content that does not present itself as political on its face, broadly termed entertainment media. The current research includes the delivery of foreign policy information in "soft news" formatting to inattentive audiences who do not seek it from traditional "hard news," and hybridization of hard and soft news in particular formats such as *The Daily Show (Baum 2003; Baym 2005)*. Much of the literature focuses on the choices that those who are not interested in politics make, particularly emphasizing both the elimination of the boundary between political and nonpolitical content as part of the decline of broader media and uninterested citizens seeking to exit from news entirely in a high-choice media environment (Prior 2007; Williams and Delli Carpini 2011). Bennett and Iyengar trace the decline of television news in part to the

loss of the "inadvertent audience," viewers who turned on the set for other reasons and were exposed to political news anyway (Bennett and Iyengar 2008). But what if these inadvertent audiences have not vanished? While listeners may tune in to The Breakfast Club for celebrity gossip, they are also offered messages about the current administration, interviews from politicians, and a whole host of implicitly political messaging from the agenda chosen by the hosts.

In more modern examples of political science and communication, the most direct precedent is encompassed within Eunji Kim's *The American Mirage*, which experimentally evidences how attitudes about economic mobility and redistribution can be shifted by exposure to television programming with rags-to-riches themes (Kim 2023, 2025). The work makes an important distinction for this paper in its design, specifying that content is credibly nonpolitical, carrying ideological messages about meritocracy while never presenting itself as making political claims. This separation distinguishes their effects from overt persuasion, and places them in the context of the broader entertainment-effects literature which treats the political and the entertaining as distinct registers and showing that the second does work that traditionally is only assumed to be occurring in the first.

As valuable as the distinction between political and entertainment media has been to the aforementioned research, Black media has rarely maintained that separation. This exists as a feature of Black media rather than incidental as implied in other hybridization accounts. As my historical work shows, the Black press blended advocacy and celebrity in the same pages from its founding, because a community denied access to mainstream institutions required a single set of outlets to carry every kind of news at once. Publications like Ebony and the Afro-American could run content about Dorothy Dandridge and the Supreme Court, or place Frederick Douglass beside Joe Louis in tandem in a way that was expected from their audiences. Sequestration of Black news from other media made the melding of "hard" and "soft" news, the cultures of politics and entertainment, a foundational characteristic of Black media. Editors of contemporary digital Black outlets still describe their work in terms of a dual mandate that predates them (Fayne 2023).

I contribute an alternative model to the study of entertainment media in the context of political communication, the hybrid-stream model illustrated in Figure II.1. The traditional model of entertainment effects emphasizes a sharp dichotomy between the streams of hard news, where political content is labeled on its face, and the entertainment stream, which presents itself as nonpolitical. Consumers may inadvertently receive political meaning that leaks through from the news stream into the entertainment stream. In the hybrid stream model, a single source can shift between a direct register, where politics is presented on its face and in a more similar fashion to the news stream, and an ambient register where political meaning can be conveyed through tone, emphasis, and content selection. While this paper focuses particularly on *The Breakfast Club* and Black media, the hybrid stream model may reimagine the scope of political communication in a media environment that is highly tabloidized and rapidly collapsing upon itself.

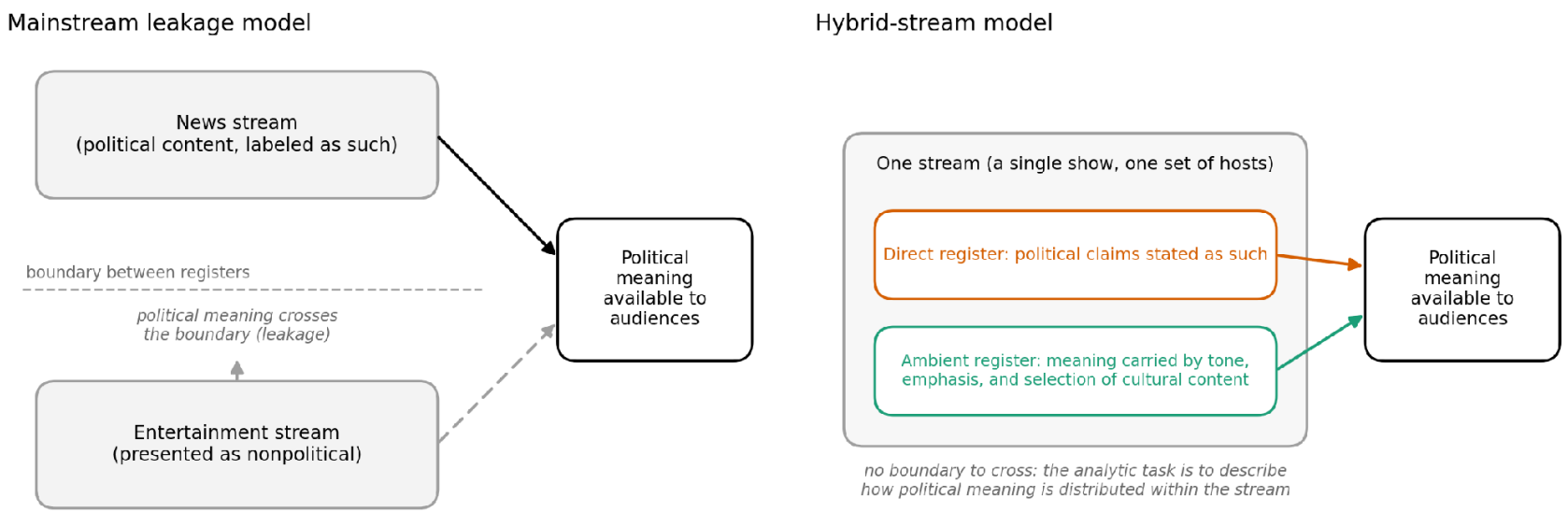


Figure II.1. Two Models of Political Meaning in Entertainment Media.
Unit: A conceptual diagram; no data are plotted. The left panel represents the traditional model of entertainment-effects research, typifying the dichotomy between entertainment and hard news as separate streams, and political meaning reaching audiences incidentally by crossing from one to the other. In contrast the right panel proposes the model for Black media, in which a single stream can carry political meaning across two registers: the direct framing, where politics is presented as such and ambient framing, in which political meaning is carried through tone, emphasis, and the selection of ostensibly cultural content.

In triangulating these three literatures, we can point to one particular outlet: a nationally distributed audio outlet, coded as entertainment and reaching a predominantly Black audience, whose political content has never been systematically measured.

Expectations

The argument yields four expectations that structure the analysis:

1. If campaigns treat the venue as mobilization infrastructure, elite appearances should concentrate before elections rather than distribute evenly across the calendar.
2. Political meaning in this venue is produced in two registers with different generators.
    a. Direct framing should respond to the national news environment and ambient framing should not. By the national news environment I mean the events that dominate national coverage, such as presidential campaigns and nationwide protests. Direct framing should track them because it is how the show addresses the news as news, while ambient framing lives in the show's own habits of selection and tone. A surge in a particular kind of story, such as crime news, could still move ambient framing through the mix of stories the show covers, which is why the format comparisons hold topic constant.
3. Following Cohen, direct framing should respond to consensus shocks, meaning events that Black institutions frame as bearing on the community as a whole, and not to cross-cutting ones, which divide the community's institutions rather than mobilizing them (Cohen 1999).
    a. The George Floyd protests and presidential elections belong to the first category. The *Dobbs* decision belongs to the second, not because abortion affects only a stigmatized subgroup in the sense of Cohen's paradigm case, but because Black Americans' views on abortion have been more divided, and more closely tied to religiosity, than those of Democrats generally, which makes it cross-cutting in the sense that matters for predicting whether a Black institution's direct register will mobilize (Newport 2020). A null result for Dobbs is consistent with this expectation, but on its own it cannot distinguish cross-cutting avoidance from a short burst of coverage lost in a long window, a limit Section VI takes up directly.
4. If ambient framing belongs to the show rather than to the news, it should vary with the show's own segment formats.

The first three expectations were fixed before the event windows were run, while the fourth was formed after the episode typology was built and is reported as exploratory.

III. *The Breakfast Club* as Case

The Breakfast Club was first aired in its traditional radio format in December 2010 on WWPR-FM, Power 105.1, as a local, New York City-focused hip-hop morning show hosted by DJ Envy, Angela Yee, and Charlamagne tha God in a crowded market. After spending a few years establishing itself and growing in popularity, it was nationally syndicated in August 2013 by Clear Channel and expanded its audience to include affiliates in Milwaukee, Tucson, Norfolk, and Birmingham (Venta 2013). By 2020, the show had risen in prominence so significantly it was added into the national Radio Hall of Fame (Radio Hall of Fame 2020). A major shift and shake-up in host lineup began when Angela Yee announced her departure in August 2022,

leaving that December, which was followed by a year of rotating guest co-hosts, prior to the joining of internet comedian Jess Hilarious as the permanent third host in February 2024 (Inside Radio 2024). The corpus therefore spans a host transition, and 2023, the rotating-host year, is a potential structural break that the format analysis in Section VI does not model. Table III.1 sets these milestones beside the distribution changes and the most prominent political appearances recorded in the census.

Table III.1. Timeline of *The Breakfast Club*

Date	Event	Source
December 2010	Launch on WWPR-FM (Power 105.1), New York, with DJ Envy, Angela Yee, and Charlamagne tha God	Clear Channel Media and Entertainment 2013
August 2013	National syndication rollout begins, with affiliates in Milwaukee, Tucson, Norfolk, and Birmingham	Venta 2013
2013	YouTube channel launched	
March 3, 2014	Live weekday simulcast on Revolt begins	Clear Channel Media and Entertainment 2013
2014	Full show posted daily as a podcast	Inside Radio 2025
April 2016	Hillary Clinton appearance (not in corpus)	Nicks 2016
October 26, 2016	Hillary Clinton appearance	Author's census
February 11, 2019	Kamala Harris appearance as a presidential primary candidate	Bryant 2019; author's census
May 22, 2020	Joe Biden appearance as the presumptive Democratic nominee	Memoli and Sotomayor 2020; author's census
2020	Black Effect Podcast Network launched by iHeartMedia and Charlamagne tha God	Inside Radio 2025
2020	Radio Hall of Fame induction, active network and syndication category	Radio Hall of Fame 2020
November 25, 2020	Barack Obama appearance as a former president	Author's census
November 12, 2021	Last day of the Revolt simulcast	Breakfast Club 2021
August 10, 2022	Angela Yee announces her departure	Moreau 2022
December 2, 2022	Angela Yee's last day as co-host	Bolden 2022
2023	Rotating guest co-hosts	Inside Radio 2024
April 17, 2023	Daily one-hour edition begins on BET and VH1	iHeartMedia 2023
August 17, 2023	Larry Elder appearance, the first Republican in the census (2024 cycle)	Author's census
February 5, 2024	Jess Hilarious joins as permanent co-host	Inside Radio 2024
October 15, 2024	Kamala Harris audio town hall in Detroit as the Democratic nominee, published in the feed on October 16	Shivaram and Breslow 2024; author's census
2025	One billion lifetime podcast downloads	Inside Radio 2025
January 2026	Full-episode video begins streaming on Netflix; record January ratings in New York	Inside Radio 2026

Note: Show history and distribution events are drawn from press and industry sources, reported as published. Political appearance dates are episode publication dates from the author's census of political elite appearances (Section V); the April 2016 Clinton appearance is documented in press coverage but is absent from the corpus and is not counted in the census. Sources: Clear Channel Media and Entertainment 2013; Venta 2013; Nicks 2016; Bryant 2019; Memoli and Sotomayor 2020; Radio Hall of Fame 2020; Breakfast Club 2021; Moreau 2022; Bolden 2022; iHeartMedia 2023; Inside Radio 2024; Shivaram and Breslow 2024; Inside Radio 2025; Inside Radio 2026.

Reach across formats

The show's case selection for this study was initially predicated upon its national reach, shown below in Table III.2 across several platforms. On radio the program runs on more than a hundred stations and reaches 6.6 million weekly listeners, and as a podcast it passed one billion

lifetime downloads in 2025 (Inside Radio 2025; Inside Radio 2026). It is consistently ranked within the top 10 and one second among all podcasts with Black listeners; its YouTube channel passed five million subscribers by 2023, and its television and streaming runs extend from Revolt to BET, VH1, and, since January 2026, Netflix (iHeartMedia 2023; Edison Research 2024). In the summer of 2020, when Nielsen put its monthly reach at eight million listeners, the *Los Angeles Times* described the show as a radio forum for the country's racial reckoning (Los Angeles Times 2020).

Table III.2. Reach of *The Breakfast Club* by Platform

Platform	Figure	Date	Source
Radio	Syndicated to more than 100 stations	2026	Inside Radio 2026
Radio	6.6 million weekly listeners	Early 2026	Inside Radio 2026
Radio	First among adults 18 to 49 and 25 to 54 in New York	January 2026	Inside Radio 2026
Podcast	One billion lifetime downloads	2025	Inside Radio 2025
Podcast	Second most listened-to podcast among Black Americans	Q4 2023	Edison Research 2024
YouTube	3.3 million subscribers	February 2019	Premiere Networks 2019
YouTube	4.1 million subscribers	January 2020	Premiere Networks 2020
YouTube	5 million subscribers	2023	iHeartMedia 2023
Television	Live weekday simulcast on Revolt	March 2014 to November 2021	Clear Channel Media and Entertainment 2013; Breakfast Club 2021
Television	Daily one-hour edition on BET and VH1	From April 2023	iHeartMedia 2023
Streaming	Full episodes on Netflix	From January 2026	Inside Radio 2026

Note: All figures are press and industry figures, reported as published by the show's distributors, trade press, or audience-measurement firms, with the date each source gives. Figures on different platforms use different measures and are not additive. Sources: Clear Channel Media and Entertainment 2013; Breakfast Club 2021; Premiere Networks 2019; Premiere Networks 2020; iHeartMedia 2023; Edison Research 2024; Inside Radio 2025; Inside Radio 2026.

While the show has a massive audience, its cross platform reach across radio, digital, and television challenges traditional political communications measures of media exposure, which are built for one channel at a time. A survey which asks about what political talk radio, news podcast, or political videos someone watches on YouTube would miss it in every format. The new media era makes undercounting of this kind more relevant than ever; Section VII returns to the problem and how it compounds the undercount of political content that topic-based measures produce.

Beyond reach, the show is also significant in terms of its historical survival. Terrestrial radio has contracted, and most locally originated Black talk programming of the kind examined in Section II has either folded or been absorbed into syndicated feeds. *The Breakfast Club* made the transition from a radio show partially through its ability to navigate the new media environment into a multiplatform property whose full episodes are available as podcasts and whose interview segments function as standalone content. The corpus is also continuous across many of these transitions through the present, in a form that can be transcribed and coded, which gives it the benefit of having an archive that is not typical to Black media platforms, historic or otherwise.

The show is also vital in that it typifies the hybrid register of its Black legacy media predecessors, since the show has no separate news segment and no separate entertainment segment. In the course of one episode, it can move between a rapper's arrest, a celebrity divorce, a listener's relationship question, and a sitting Vice President without changing tone, and the political content is delivered by the same hosts in the same voice as the gossip. This blending is discursive integration in Baym's sense, but it is also something older, a practice Black media mastered long before it entered the broader media landscape, and that I locate in the founding structure of the Black press (Baym 2005). The show does, however, carry named recurring segments with different genre labels, which Section VI uses as a source of variation: Donkey of the Day is presented as comedic commentary, Rumor Report as gossip, and guest interviews as a format of their own.

The case selection relies on the reach, longevity, and existence of a transcribable record, and hopes to eventually extend this analysis to the broader Black audio and digital media ecosystem. The study seeks to establish the phenomenon of the hybrid register, measure its structure, and to examine the response of the structure to variation.

IV. Data and Method

Drawing upon the measurement potential of *The Breakfast Club*'s extensive record of transcripts, I construct two key instruments: a computational content analysis of 5,518 episodes of the show, outlined here in Section IV, and a subsequent census of 131 political elite appearances, outlined in Section V. This section provides details of the shape of the complete corpus, describes its construction, introduces the classification pipeline alongside key illustrative examples, and reports both the scope and the limitations of the data.

Corpus

The corpus consists of 5,518 episodes of *The Breakfast Club* published between late 2014 and mid-2026, constructed and downloaded through the TapeSearch API (tapesearch.com), a podcast transcript service. TapeSearch transcribed the episodes with Whisper, and the transcripts were downloaded as JSON files with segment-level timestamps for most episodes and as SRT caption files for the 962 episodes without JSON output.[2] Episode metadata, including titles and publication dates, was joined to the transcripts from a separate manifest.

The episodes were segmented into 179,438 chunks of approximately 2,000 characters each, with boundaries aligned to transcript segments rather than cut at fixed character offsets. The analysis classifies chunks rather than whole episodes because a four-hour morning show contains many distinct segments, and a single episode-level label would bury framing that appears late in the show under whatever dominates its opening.

Episode typology

The feed is not homogeneous, and the distribution of chunks per episode in Figure IV.1 is bimodal, with a sharp mode at four to nine chunks, a broad mode centered at forty-five to fifty-five, and a scattered middle band between them. Rather than cutting the feed on length alone, each episode was assigned a product type from its title conventions and length: full show,

2 TapeSearch's documentation describes its transcription model and pipeline.

standalone interview, Donkey of the Day clip, other labeled segment, unlabeled clip, unknown middle-band episode, rerun, or cross-post from another show. Of the 5,299 dated episodes, 1,256 are full shows, 1,673 are standalone interviews, 876 are Donkey of the Day clips, 263 are other labeled segments, 188 are unlabeled clips, 624 are unknown middle-band episodes, and 419 are reruns or cross-posts, as Table IV.1 reports by year.

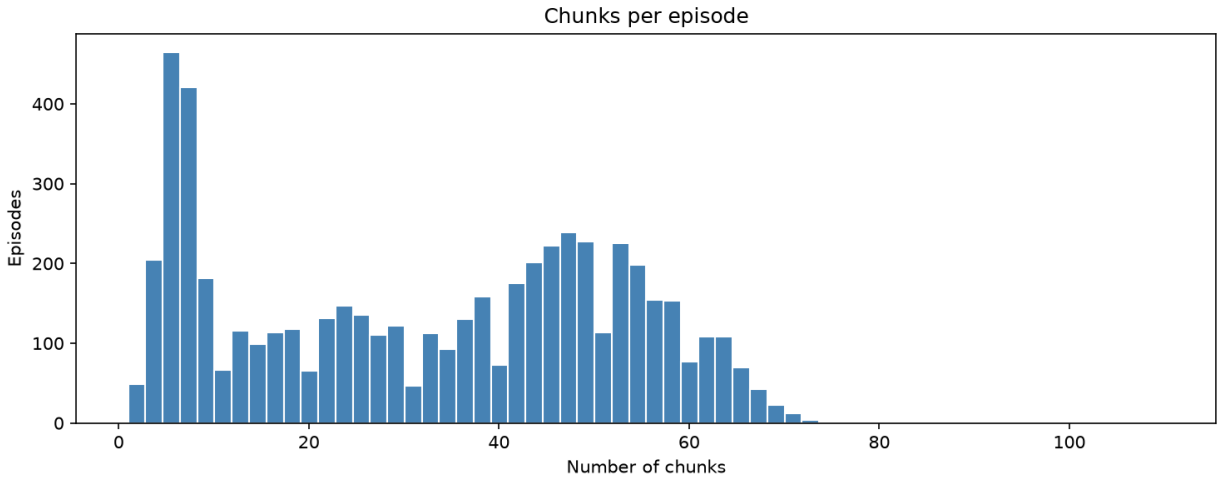


Figure IV.1. Distribution of Chunks per Episode.
Unit: All 5,518 episodes in the corpus; the unit is the episode, and each bar counts episodes with a given number of chunks of approximately 2,000 characters. The short-clip mode, at about four to nine chunks, is mostly standalone interviews and clips; the full-show mode, at about forty-five to fifty-five chunks, is full morning shows.

Full shows are the analytic sample for every time-series and event-window result. They are the only product type that carries a whole morning's mix of content, so their composition is not itself an editorial choice about what to clip. Standalone interviews are added in robustness checks, Donkey of the Day clips are compared with full shows as a format of their own, and reruns, cross-posts, and same-day duplicate uploads are excluded everywhere.

Table IV.1. Corpus Coverage by Year and Product Type

Year	Full show	Interview	Donkey clip	Other segment	Unlabeled clip	Unknown (middle band)	Rerun / cross-post	Episodes	Chunks
2014	0	2	0	0	0	0	0	2	29
2015	0	102	0	0	0	7	0	109	2,114
2016	12	9	1	10	0	109	18	159	6,431
2017	6	124	0	0	0	100	12	242	9,694
2018	27	124	2	2	0	81	12	248	10,501
2019	104	116	11	2	6	24	18	281	13,092
2020	87	119	0	1	1	27	33	268	12,594
2021	102	117	0	5	0	24	22	270	13,185
2022	147	126	79	5	13	39	47	456	15,154
2023	181	94	252	11	44	65	34	681	19,575
2024	232	254	208	34	15	15	69	827	26,841
2025	233	325	204	113	51	82	89	1,097	29,751
2026 (to May)	125	161	119	80	58	51	65	659	15,502
Total	**1,256**	**1,673**	**876**	**263**	**188**	**624**	**419**	**5,299**	**174,463**

Note: Dated episodes of *The Breakfast Club*, 2014 to May 2026. Cells count episodes except the final column, which counts chunks of approximately 2,000 characters. 219 episodes and 4,975 chunks lack a usable date; they appear in corpus-wide counts of 5,518 episodes and 179,438 chunks but are not included in any of the time series. Reruns and

cross-posts are excluded from every analysis, and advertisement chunks are included in the chunk counts here and excluded from every denominator in Sections V- VII.

Table IV.1 reveals that the corpus includes very few full shows prior to 2019, with twelve in 2016, six in 2017, and twenty-seven in 2018 before rising to a hundred or more in every year after. The early feed consists mostly of standalone interviews and shorter clips of episodes. Consequently, every time series analysis and event-window result is estimated from 2019 onward; topic-composition from prior to 2019 is included but segmented due to the thinness of the data. Standalone Donkey of the Day clips begin in 2022, so the format comparison in Section VI is a comparison within the 2022 to 2026 window, even though the model includes year fixed effects across the full range.

Classification pipeline

The classification pipeline occurred in stages, with prompts recorded in Appendix A alongside its version history. Stage A, corpus assembly and the metadata join, involves no model and is described under Corpus above. Table IV.2 summarizes every stage, including the two model stages that follow, which were run through the Anthropic Messages API in batch mode.

Table IV.2. Classification Pipeline Stages

Stage	Model	Input	Output	Gate
A	None	Episode transcripts (JSON or SRT) and the episode metadata CSV	179,438 chunks of approximately 2,000 characters with episode metadata	None
B	claude-haiku-4-5-20251001	All 179,438 chunks	Primary topic (eleven categories), from the Phase 2, Version 1 run; framing flag and framing register with a one-sentence rationale, from the Phase 2, Version 2 recheck	None
C	claude-sonnet-5	Chunks with the framing flag set	Ideology score from 1 to 7 and a one-sentence rationale	Framing flag is true, independent of topic
D	Not yet run	Framed chunks discussing sexuality	Valence score (designed, not finalized)	Gated on Stage E
E	Not yet run	Stratified reliability sample	Human codes for agreement statistics	None

Note: Stage letters follow the prompt record in Appendix A, which reproduces each prompt verbatim with its version history. Stage A involves no model, Stages B and C were run through the Anthropic Messages API in batch mode, and Stages D and E are designed but not yet run. The framing register records whether political meaning is stated (direct) or carried (ambient).

Stage B: topic and political framing. The first pass occurs in Stage B, using claude-haiku-4-5-20251001, assigning a primary topic from an 11 category typology and, as an independent judgment, a flag for whether the chunk carries political, civil-rights, or policy-relevant framing regardless of its topic. Topic labels come from the Phase 2, Version 1 run, whose typology of politics and government, crime and policing, celebrity and entertainment, sports, business and economy, health, relationships and lifestyle, music industry, comedy and banter, advertisement, and other was carried forward unchanged.

The framing flag comes from the Phase 2, Version 2 recheck of all 179,438 chunks, which also records, for each framed chunk, whether the political meaning is stated or carried. The classifier records this basis as explicit or implicit, and these values operationalize direct and ambient framing respectively; the classifier's own labels appear only in Appendix A.

To capture the theoretical assessment of the paper, and the ambient/direct distinction, the register field in Version 2 was added to treat topic and framing independently. With these classifiers, chunks without politics as their primary classifier like celebrity content could still be counted as carrying political content in either register.

Stage C: ideological position. Stage C utilizes a sharper and stronger model, claude-sonnet-5, to score each chunk flagged as carrying political framing on a seven-point Likert scale running from strongly liberal at 1 through centrist at 4 to strongly conservative at 7, mirroring the self-placement conventions of the American National Election Studies.[3] Scoring is gated on the framing flag and is independent of topic, so a sports segment that turns to athlete activism is scored while a purely descriptive recap of an election result is not.

Advertisement chunks. None of the framing and ideology denominators in Sections V-VII include chunks identified as advertisements. They are reported separately as a share of overall episode runtime. The ideology classification, however, was still applied. Across the corpus, 3,074 of 16,040 advertisement chunks, or 19 percent, carry a framing flag, mostly promotions for other iHeart podcasts on Black history and policing and brand campaigns rather than political advertising, and 3,034 received an ideology score, which is 6 percent of all scored chunks, with a mean of 3.51. As this promotional content is not the show directly speaking, it falls outside the intended measurement of the paper, regardless of whether it is politically framed or not.[4] With advertisement chunks excluded, 47,932 of the corpus's 163,398 remaining chunks carry political framing, or 29.3 percent, and this ads-excluded rate is the framing rate the paper reports. Excluding the 2,761 scored advertisement chunks and the duplicate uploads moves the headline ideology distribution from 54.9 / 40.2 / 4.9 to 57.0 / 37.8 / 5.3 percent liberal, centrist, and conservative, a two-point shift toward the liberal side because advertisement content clusters near the midpoint. Whether the political content of these ad breaks is relevant is left open for further research.

Direct and ambient framing in the transcript

The classifier applies the distinction defined in the introduction: a chunk is coded as direct framing when it states a position, and as ambient framing when its tone, emphasis, or selection carries political meaning without stating it. The examples below are drawn from full transcripts and provide evidence of how three stories about the same issue (crime) can operate in these distinct registers. The difference in register is not the same as a difference in subject.

3 The Stage C prompt includes an instruction to output only the final score and rationale without narrating intermediate reasoning, added after the model's narrated self-corrections consumed output length in an earlier stage. The instruction changes the format of the response, not the judgment requested; the full prompt appears in Appendix A.

4 Reading the scored advertisement chunks shows two kinds of content: promotional reads for other podcasts on the iHeart network, many of them about Black history, policing, or politics, and brand campaigns tied to Black cultural moments.

Each example is provided alongside the classifier's one sentence rationale to understand the classification process. Quotations are only edited for length or to clarify errors from the transcript from the Whisper output; elisions are marked and obvious transcription errors are corrected in brackets.

Example 1. Direct framing on a crime story. The first example comes from a full show on July 20, 2023, when the subject was Carlee Russell, whose reported abduction in Alabama had just been exposed as a hoax. Charlamagne took up the story in the Donkey of the Day segment:

> "Don't let that ever discourage you from raising awareness to the epidemic that is missing black women and children in this country. 40% of missing people in this country are colored. […] I don't want to hear y'all say 'see, they wasted the police officers' time.' No, they didn't. Police were doing their job. […] They don't really look for us. They don't contribute resources to looking for us. Hell, they couldn't even find Carlee and she wasn't even really missing."

While the topic is a crime story, the framing shows the host, Charlamagne, taking a clear stance about the allocation of attention and resources by race of law enforcement.

The classifier's rationale reads: *explicitly frames missing Black women and children as a systemic civil-rights issue, critiques police resource allocation and investigative practices toward this community.* The chunk is coded as direct, with an ideology score of 2, indicating it liberal ideological stance.

Example 2. Ambient framing on a crime story. The second example comes from a full show on September 15, 2023, in which Jess Hilarious reads a news item about a Seattle police union officer recorded on body camera joking about a woman killed by a patrol car and then plays the audio:

> "Now listen closely, guys. The person that you are about to listen to is the vice president of the Seattle police officers guild. […] So take a listen to what leaders of the police guild sound like, even when they know somebody could be listening, because they obviously had their body cam on."

Following the clip of the audio, where the officer says the victim "had limited value" and suggests writing an $11,000 check, the hosts, respond by saying "every life has value," and the conversation turns to how settlements price a life, with a comparison to the case involving the murder of Breonna Taylor. There is no point in which the host states an explicit position on policing or a policy stance, with the political meaning living in the decision of what was chosen to bring to the airwaves, in their instruction to "listen closely," in the correction of the wire copy's "appearing to make light" to "he was making light," and in the closing comparison to a prior racialized case. The classifier's rationale reads: *sympathetic emphasis on the victim and critical framing of police leadership's callous response, with implicit invocation of systemic injustice and racialized policing narratives, without explicit policy commentary.* The chunk is coded as ambient, with an ideology score of 2.

Example 3. No framing on a crime story. The third example comes from a full show on October 9, 2025, when the subject was Sean Combs's federal sentence and where he would serve it:

> "How do you pick your prison anyway? Is there like a brochure? […] You can't choose to go to federal prison. You go to a federal prison when you got a federal charge. But within, though, there's a couple that he could be at. His team will look at, of course, they wanted to be closer to his family, they wanted to be easy for people to visit him, but they also are trying to get him out of there."

While this segment also includes conversation about a Black public figure, incarceration, and the federal justice system, it is coded as no political framing because it is simply procedural. There is no stated position, no tonal evidence of treatment, and no comparison to broader issues surrounding criminal justice. The exchange contains no position, no emphasis on treatment, and no comparison to anyone else. The classifier's rationale reads: *neutral procedural discussion of how federal prison assignment works, using a specific case as a conversational example without commentary on the justice system, policing, or policy.* This is the case that Version 2 of the framing prompt was written to exclude, and the many chunks like it are what keep the ambient category from meaning "any story about a Black person and the law."

Three further examples appear in Appendix E: ambient framing on a celebrity story, direct framing on a sports story, and a boundary case in which the classifier correctly declines to code a Black defendant's legal trouble as political despite pointed host commentary.

Example 1 comes from Donkey of the Day, as does the direct example on a sports story in Appendix E. That is not an accident of selection: when Charlamagne explicitly takes a position, he often does so in his own segment, which anticipates the format result reported in Section VI.

These examples all highlight what the data measures. The direct register (Example 1) directly engages the political claim textually and could be quoted as a clear position. The ambient register (Example 2) places the claim in what the hosts chose to spend airtime on, in the sympathetic tone of the language, and what they leave unsaid in the space where a direct claim could lie (and where a listener who shares the frame might hear it). Example 3, no framing, is what remains when the subject is a Black public figure's legal trouble and the hosts simply report it. Chunks like this are common in the corpus, and their presence is what keeps the ambient register from collapsing into "any story about a Black person and the law," which is the condition under which the register counts can be read as measuring framing rather than subject matter.

Prompt revision and its consequences

In early analysis, the framing classifier was modified in a way which did shift results.[5] The revision is reported here rather than in an appendix because it bears directly on how much weight the ideology findings can carry. A manual audit of Version 1 found a false positive rate of roughly 25 percent, concentrated in descriptive coverage of celebrity legal proceedings, where neutral procedural recaps of courtroom events were being flagged as political. Version 2 excludes such coverage by name, adds the register field, and includes worked examples of each

5 A pilot design that assigned a single political/entertainment/mixed label was replaced before any reported result; Appendix A reproduces it as Phase 1. The two-field instrument reported here is Phase 2, and its two versions are Appendix A's Phase 2, Version 1 and Version 2.

register and of the neutral case, and the full corpus of 179,438 chunks was reclassified under it, and Table IV.3 compares the two versions.

Table IV.3. Framing Flag and Ideology Distribution Under the Two Phase 2 Classifier Versions

	Version 1	Version 2 (current)	Change
Chunks flagged political	69,826	51,006	−27.0%
Share of corpus	38.9%	28.4%	
Liberal (1–3)	42.2%	54.9%	+12.7 pts
Centrist (4)	53.6%	40.2%	−13.4 pts
Conservative (5–7)	4.2%	4.9%	+0.7 pts

Note: Corpus-wide, all 179,438 chunks, including advertisement chunks as the pipeline was run. The share of corpus is flagged chunks divided by all chunks. Ideology shares are percentages of scored chunks within each version; Version 1 figures are based on 69,290 scored chunks. With advertisement chunks excluded, the Version 2 framing rate is 29.3 percent of chunks, and with advertisement chunks and duplicate uploads excluded, the Version 2 ideology distribution used in Section VI is 57.0 / 37.8 / 5.3 percent.

In hand coding, the roughly 25 percent false positive rate is quite close to the 27 percent reduction in flagged chunks, signalling consistency but still not a formal validation. The thirteen-point shift in the liberal and centrist shares means that prompt quality is load-bearing for every claim in Sections V and VI. Two design features of the analysis reduce that exposure: the event-window and format results are comparisons within a single classifier, so a constant false positive rate cancels out of them, and the format result is also reported with the crime and celebrity categories dropped, where false positives concentrated, and the effect grows rather than shrinks under that restriction.

Reliability: to be completed

Reliability for the Claude API classifiers is still pending; a stratified human-coded reliability samplehas been drawn but not yet coded. The sample is stratified by transcript format, JSON or SRT, and by framing register, direct, ambient, or none, and it will report agreement on the framing flag and a confusion matrix for the eleven-category topic label rather than a single agreement statistic across both. Subsequently, the three results surrounding the level of framing rate, concentration of ambient chunks at the ideological midpoint, and the ideology comparison across issue registers in Section VII must be read through the lens of this caveat. One known scoring miss, a pro-life caller coded left of center, surfaced in the keyword reading and is the kind of error the check is designed to quantify.

Known limitations

The data is marked by several limitations.

Transcript coverage. Marked on time-series figures, some of the data used is SRT-sources as opposed to the JSON standard of the rest of the data, concentrated around 2021 and 2022. The stacked-area figure in Section VI drops months with fewer than 100 chunks, and Figure D.1 masks topic-months with fewer than 60 chunks. Whisper renders proper names inconsistently, so counts of named mentions are unreliable, and every keyword measure in the paper uses topic terms rather than names alone.

Classifier. Event-window dates were chosen prior to any results, but not formally pre-registered. The advertisement label may miss some promotional content, particularly when it falls into a segment where the majority is the host talking. About 7 percent of full-show chunks since 2019, advertisement chunks excluded, contain promotional language without an advertisement label, but dropping all of them changes the framing rate by 0.1 points, the ambient rate by 0.1 points, and the ambient share of framed content by 0.4 points, and no topic-level register rate in Table VI.1 moves by more than 0.8 points, so the results are reported on the full sample. At the ideology stage, 478 of the 51,006 chunks flagged under Version 2, or 0.9 percent, have no ideology score and are treated as missing. Most of these failures date from the Version 1 run and were not retried when Version 2 was reconciled. They included responses where the score could not be parsed, and requests stopped from batch level errors. The unparsed responses contain valid scores for 392 of the 478 chunks, and those recoverable scores lean more liberal than the scored sample, so leaving them out slightly understates the show's liberal lean rather than overstating it.

Corpus hygiene. The third set concerns corpus hygiene, where a title-match check for near-duplicate episodes, defined as the same normalized title within three days, found 35 candidates, 31 of which were not already excluded as reruns, and most of these are same-day video and audio uploads of the same interview, while a few are legitimately different "Part 2" episodes. The later copy of each same-day, same-title pair is excluded, which removes 24 episodes, under 1 percent of the corpus, and keeps a single conversation from being counted twice in any denominator.

With the complete classified corpus now outlined in detail, the next section turns to the second instrument: the census of political elites. Using this same episode feed, Section V provides the census to establish an independent measure of how political actors choose to come to the show, and links the coded content to these appearances to see how they may shift the register of conversation.

V. Elite Appearances: A Census

Design

From Biden and Harris to most of a presidential primary field, it is clear that elites believe there is political value in these spaces, and their appearances represent contemporary forays into the Black counterpublic, building upon a history of the complex intersection of Black popular culture with Black politics. To quantify elite engagement on The Breakfast Club, the census enumerates every appearance on the show by a political elite. For clarity of intent, the definition restricts political elite to include only candidates for public office, sitting and former elected officials, appointed officials, and party officials. Guest's status is coded by their position at the air date of the episode, with several elites appearing in the corpus in different roles across appearances. The primary census explicitly excludes a more expansive version of elites which would include activists, heads of civil rights organizations, political commentators, and celebrities with political profiles. This conservative boundary is a strict test; each exclusion is logged with a one-line rationale in Table B.1 in Appendix B. In line with recent work that addresses how cultural agents can reshape political communications, and the trajectory of political guests across podcasts, we treat each appearance as a unit of political communication itself (DeMets and Spiro 2025; Kim and York 2026).

In the coding of candidate episodes three signals were used: office words in titles of episodes including political positions, a seed list of roughly seventy named political figures, and on-air introduction or direct address patterns within the transcripts such as “we got Senator … in the building” or “Madam Vice President.” Every episode flagged by a title signal was reviewed by hand, and episodes flagged only by transcript signals were reviewed in order of signal strength, with the stopping point reported. In all, the coding yielded 531 candidate episodes reviewed, of which 168 were coded as appearances, 262 as not appearances, 99 as political guests outside the definition, and 2 as unresolvable. Two episodes with former elected officials were added under the rule that former officials count in any capacity, giving 170 coded appearances before de-duplication; a model-assisted pre-coding pass, with every decision confirmed by hand, is described in Appendix B. Figure B.1 in Appendix B traces each step from the 531 reviewed episodes to the final census.

The analysis was at the appearance level, meaning any separate interviews that were also added to a full show were grouped and counted once in the analysis. The appearances can only count episodes that exist in the corpus as outlined in Section IV; for example Hillary Clinton’s April 2016 visit, which is documented in press coverage but absent from the corpus, is the known example of an appearance it misses (Nicks 2016). One special-format event is included: an audio town hall that Kamala Harris held in Detroit as the Democratic nominee on October 15, 2024, which appears in the feed the following day and is counted as an appearance with a format note (Shivaram and Breslow 2024).

Timing. Each appearance is coded by its days to the nearest relevant election, signed so that negative values fall before the election, and by race type, primary or general contest, and office level. For guests not personally on a ballot, the nearest federal or statewide election in the guest’s jurisdiction is used, with a flag recording whether the guest was a candidate in it.

Partisanship. Each appearance records the guest’s party and whether the guest held office at the time. Where a sitting officeholder appeared during an announced campaign, the inclusion category is coded as candidate and the held-office flag is set to true, so that both facts are retained.

Appearance context. Each appearance also records whether it was a solo interview or part of a larger segment, its duration, and whether it fell during an announced campaign. Table B.2 in Appendix B lists every variable, its definition, its type and allowed values, and the values observed in the census.

Results

The first expectation posits that elite appearances should concentrate before elections as opposed to simply being distributed across the calendar, particularly as it relates to the venue as a potential mobilization infrastructure. After de-duplication, the census contains 131 appearances by 76 people; Appendix B describes the duplicate copies removed and the episodes excluded. Table V.1 breaks the appearances down by inclusion category, and Table V.2 reports them by year as a rate per 100 episodes.

Table V.1. Appearances by Inclusion Category

Category	Appearances
Candidate	58
Sitting elected official	42
Former elected official	17
Appointed official	8
Former appointed official	3
Party official	3
Total	**131**

Note: Census of political elite appearances, April 2015 to May 2026, with status coded as of the air date, so that a sitting officeholder appearing during an announced campaign is coded as a candidate. In 41 percent of appearances the guest was personally on an upcoming ballot.

Table V.2. Elite Appearances by Year

Year	Appearances	Full-show and interview episodes	Per 100 episodes
2015	1	81	1.2
2016	1	21	4.8
2017	3	130	2.3
2018	6	151	4.0
2019	17	220	7.7
2020	12	206	5.8
2021	7	219	3.2
2022	11	273	4.0
2023	9	275	3.3
2024	30	486	6.2
2025	27	558	4.8
2026 (to May)	7	195	3.6

Note: Census window April 2015 to May 2026, with the rate given as appearances per 100 full-show and standalone interview episodes published in the same year. Reruns and cross-posts are excluded from the denominator in every year.

Timing. Political elites do not drift toward the show as an election approaches but arrive instead in its final month, as Table V.3 shows.

Table V.3. Elite Appearances Before Federal General Elections Relative to the Show's Publication Calendar

Window before a federal general election	Appearances in window	Share of appearances	Share of all episodes	Ratio	p (one-sided)
30 days	13	9.9%	4.2%	2.37	.004
60 days	17	13.0%	8.3%	1.55	.046
90 days	18	13.7%	11.7%	1.18	.27
180 days	32	24.4%	22.2%	1.10	.30

Note: Census window April 2015 to May 2026; 131 appearances compared with 2,815 full-show and standalone interview episodes published in the same window. The share of appearances is the share of the 131 appearances that aired within the window; the share of all episodes is the share of the 2,815 episodes that aired within the same window. The ratio divides the first share by the second, so values above 1 indicate that appearances concentrate in the window beyond what the show's own publication schedule would produce. Reruns and cross-posts are excluded, and all p-values are one-sided.

In the 30 days directly preceding a federal general election, the appearance rate is 2.4 times the show's ordinary rate. By 60 days the ratio has fallen to 1.5, and at 90 and 180 days appearances are indistinguishable from the show's normal schedule, which makes the surge both sharp and

late. The surge is also a presidential-cycle phenomenon, since within 90 days presidential cycles run at 1.5 times baseline, with 15 of 65 presidential-cycle appearances falling in the window ($p = .07$), while midterm cycles run at half of baseline, with 3 of 66. The shape matches what the content analysis finds in Section VI, where direct political framing rises in presidential run-ups and does not move at midterms, so two independent measures trace the same calendar.

In Figure V.1, there is a second peak that is clearly visible within the days-to-election distribution about a year prior to the 2020 election, clearly produced by the 2019 Democratic primary field, in which Cory Booker, Kamala Harris, Bernie Sanders, Andrew Yang, Pete Buttigieg, Julián Castro, Elizabeth Warren, Beto O'Rourke, Deval Patrick, and Marianne Williamson all appeared. 2019 boasts the highest appearance rate in the census, at 7.7 per 100 episodes, which emphasizes the show's function as an early proving ground for Democratic primaries and as a late-in-the-race channel for mobilization. Primaries are not included in the election calendar used for the timing analysis, so it is likely that the concentration reported above understates elite use of the venue.

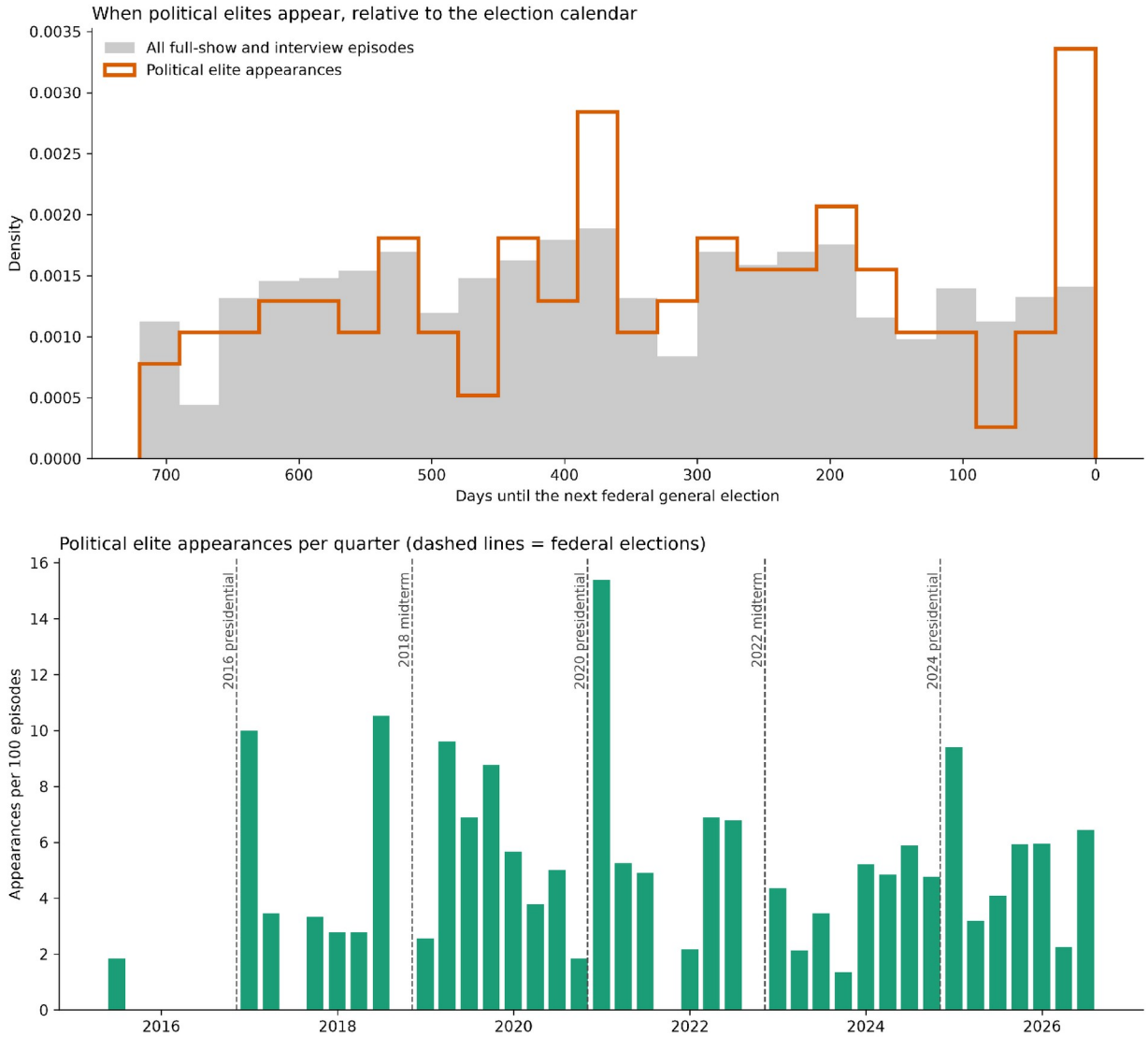


Figure V.1. Timing of Political Elite Appearances Relative to Federal General Elections.
Unit: Census of political elite appearances, April 2015 to May 2026, and all full-show and standalone interview episodes in the same window, reruns excluded. Left panel: the distribution of days until the next federal general election for the 131 elite appearances (orange outline) and for the 2,815 episodes (gray fill), each scaled as a density so that the two can be compared regardless of count; the horizontal axis runs from about 720 days before an election at left to election day at right. Right panel: elite appearances per 100 full-show and standalone interview episodes in each calendar quarter (January to March, April to June, July to September, and October to December, so an election year's final bar contains the November election and the weeks after it), with dashed vertical lines marking the 2016, 2018, 2020, 2022, and 2024 federal general elections.

Partisanship. Of the 131 appearances, 119 are by Democrats, 8 by Republicans, and 4 by independents, all in the 2024 cycle, as Table V.4 shows by cycle. All of the few Republican appearances fall within the 2024 or 2026 cycle, with guests including Larry Elder, Vivek Ramaswamy, Nikki Haley, Byron Donalds, Lara Trump, Nancy Mace, and Curtis Sliwa, and Republicans cluster tightly before the election, with 3 of 8 appearing within 90 days against 13 of 119 Democrats (ratio 3.2, p = .06). With single-digit cases I treat this pattern as description rather than a finding, but it does mark the 2024 cycle as the first time the venue became contested territory. Including campaign surrogates in the definition would add one Republican appearance within 90 days and would not change the pattern, and surrogates are logged in the exclusion file.

Table V.4. Party of Guest by Election Cycle

Cycle	Democratic	Independent	Republican	Total
2016 presidential	2	0	0	2
2018 midterm	9	0	0	9
2020 presidential	26	0	0	26
2022 midterm	20	0	0	20
2024 presidential	27	4	6	37
2026 midterm	35	0	2	37
All	**119**	**4**	**8**	**131**

Note: Census of political elite appearances, April 2015 to May 2026. Each appearance is assigned to the next federal general election after its air date, so the 2026 midterm cycle includes appearances from November 2024 through May 2026.

The timing and partisan results together show campaigns concentrating their visits in the final month before presidential elections, which supports the first expectation at the 30-day and 60-day windows and not at the wider windows. The pattern is consistent with a venue that campaigns treat as mobilization infrastructure for a specific electorate at specific moments, and it leaves open what the show does in the rest of the calendar, which is interrogated in the following section.

When politicians come, the register changes

The combination of the content analysis and census tests two claims central to the paper: that politicians arriving in the final month bring direct framing with them, and that most political content in both registers occurs with no politician present. By linking the census and content data, we can examine what happens to the show's framing when a political elite is in the room and driving the conversation. The linkage separated the stand alone interviews and full shows into three distinct categories: elite, meaning an appearance from the politicians included within the census,;borderline, where an episode included political guests that were excluded

from the primary census such as activists and commentators; and other. 39 duplications of census appearances were dropped from every group so that a full show could not land in "other" while its interview copy sat in "elite." Standalone interviews are the main comparison, since in an interview the episode is the conversation, whereas in a full show the elite segment is diluted by the rest of the morning, and Table V.5 reports the three interview groups.

Table V.5. Direct and Ambient Framing in Standalone Interviews by Guest Type

Interview group	Episodes	Chunks	Direct framing	Ambient framing	Ambient share of framed
Elite (census)	88	2,763	66.5%	5.7%	7.9%
Borderline (activists, commentators)	47	1,446	60.3%	8.2%	12.0%
Other interviews	1,458	45,441	16.2%	9.6%	37.3%

Note: Standalone interview episodes within the census window, April 2015 to May 2026. Direct and ambient framing are shares of chunks; the ambient share of framed content is the share of framed chunks carrying ambient framing. Advertisement chunks and duplicate copies of census appearances are excluded. With year fixed effects and standard errors clustered by episode, elite interviews differ from other interviews by +50.5 points on direct framing, −3.8 on ambient framing, and −30.7 on the ambient share of framed content (all $p < .001$), and borderline interviews differ by +44.2, −0.8 (not significant), and −26.6. Full shows show the same pattern at lower magnitude, with elite full shows running +24.0 points on direct framing and −16.7 on the ambient share. * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$.

The evidence is clear: when a politician is the guest, the show moves into the direct register, with two-thirds of chunks in elite interviews carrying direct framing against one in six in other interviews, and the ambient share of framed content falling from 37 percent to 8 percent (Figure V.2). The ambient register is the show's own voice, and when a politician sits across the table, the conversation switches to conventional political talk. The shift is partially evident by construction: a politician should logically discuss policy and produce political content by definition. Activist and commentator interviews look nearly the same in terms of composition as elite ones, at 60 percent direct with a similar collapse in the ambient share, and the confidence intervals overlap. The shift therefore is driven by political guests in general and not only politicians; politicians are distinguished by their timing of appearance rather than the register they bring.

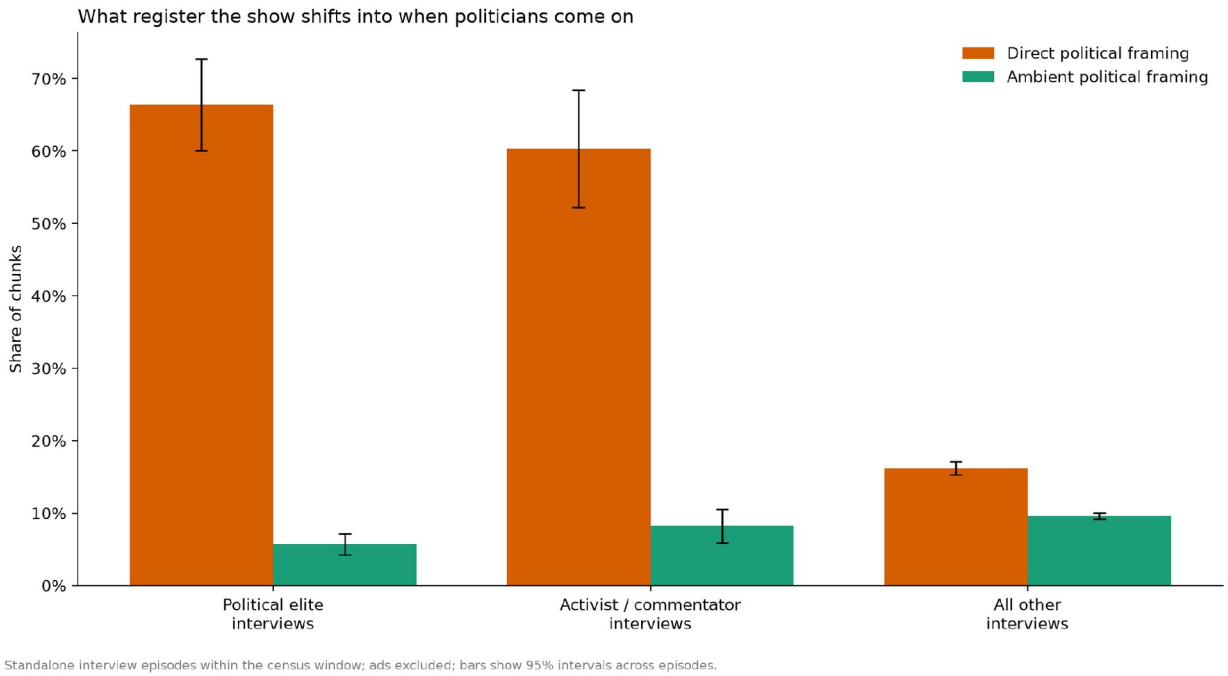


Figure V.2. Direct and Ambient Framing in Standalone Interviews by Guest Type.
Unit: Standalone interview episodes within the census window, April 2015 to May 2026. Each bar is the share of chunks in that group carrying direct framing (orange) or ambient framing (green). Advertisement chunks are excluded, and error bars show 95 percent intervals across episodes.

The next comparison places elite appearances in contrast with the broader full corpus. After computing from the group means in Table V.5 and their full-show counterparts, elite-appearance episodes account for 10.4 percent of the direct political content in the linked sample and 2.6 percent of the ambient content. The majority of the political talk in the show is coming from the regular programming and hosts themselves, and not the politicians who are occasional visitors. The show is doing significant political work on its own terms, highlighting the theoretical support for the venue as an institution of the counterpublic rather than a simple campaign stop.

Looking contextually within elite interviews, appearances within 90 days of an election are the most direct, at 88.5 percent against 64.5 percent on 8 episodes, while Republican interviews are almost entirely direct, at 98.2 percent direct and 0.4 percent ambient on 6 episodes, and presidential and midterm cycles do not differ in register, at 65.0 against 68.0 percent. Again, these patterns are reported as a description due to the small amount of cells. Elite interview content also scores about 0.29 points more liberal on the seven-point scale than other interview content with register held constant ($p = .025$), but this difference rests on the unvalidated ideology measure and mostly reflects that nine in ten guests are Democrat. For counterpublic theory, the linked results locate the campaign visit as an interruption of the show's ordinary register rather than as its source, which is the distinction the rest of the paper develops.

VI. Findings

If the campaign visit marks simply an interruption by political elites into the broader political landscape of the show, the question remains of what the regular beat of the show looks like. The following findings reveal where the majority of the political meaning of the show lies.

Section VI establishes the show's composition, where the ambient and direct framing outlined in Section IV exist within its content, and what factors shift its content and register.

Composition: what the show is made of, and what changed

The composition data substantiates the introduction's claim of how political content has roughly doubled over the past decade, and emphasizes both its size and what type of content drives it. In full shows, politics-and-government content ran near 10 percent of non-advertisement runtime in ordinary years from 2019 through 2023, spiked to 19 percent of runtime in 2020, and has held between 14 and 19 percent of runtime since 2024, as Figure VI.1 shows and Table D.1 in Appendix D reports in full. The pattern is an election-year pulse on a flat baseline, followed by a higher plateau after 2024. Across all non-rerun formats, which is the only way to reach back before 2019, the politics share rose from 7.5 percent of chunks in 2015 to 2018 to 15.6 percent of chunks in 2024 to 2026, roughly doubling, but the early years are thin and consist mostly of interviews and unlabeled episodes, so the full-show series from 2019 is the one the paper relies on.

Breaking this change into a comparison within-format and between-format shows us that the rise is not simply an artifact of what clips the show is publishing. The cleanest comparison, 2021 to 2023 against 2024 to 2026, shows the politics share rising 4.8 points, all of it within formats. The comparison of 2019 to 2021 with 2024 to 2026 attributes 92 percent of a 2.6-point rise to change within formats, and the long comparison from 2015 to 2018 attributes 83 percent of an 8-point rise to it, with the remainder reflecting the shift from interview-heavy to full-show-heavy publishing. Within full shows alone, politics went from 12.8 percent of chunks in 2019 to 2021 to 16.6 percent of chunks in 2024 to 2026. Rather than telling the story of a feed simply adding more political clips, it shows that the show has become more political in its content as a whole, evidencing its political voice as opposed to distribution strategy.

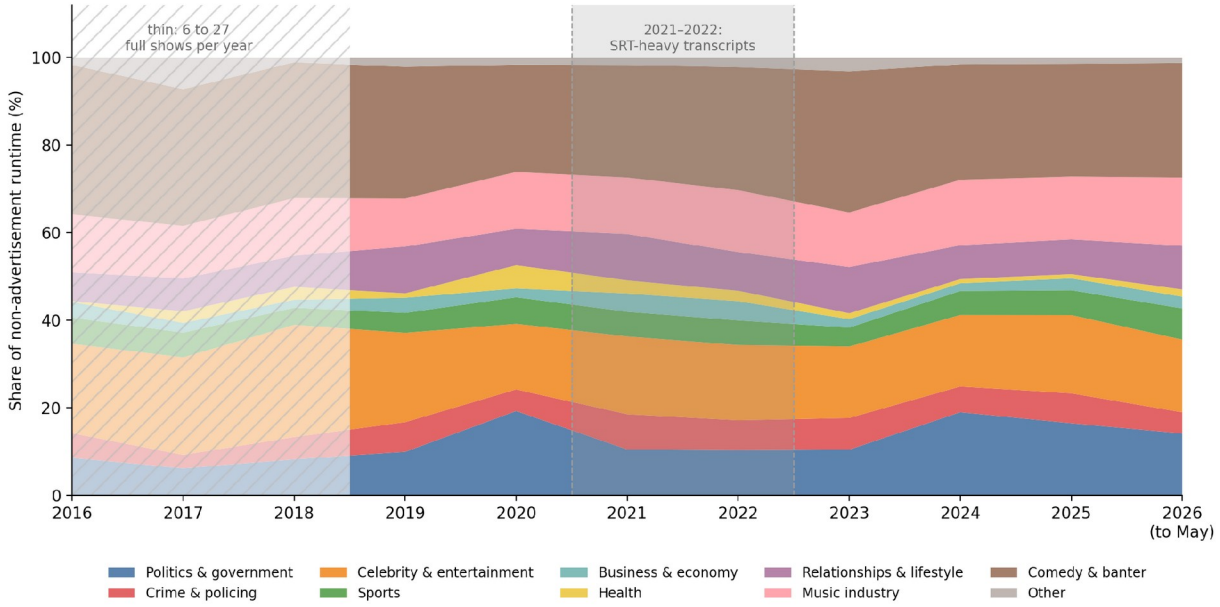


Figure VI.1. Topic Composition by Year.
Unit: Full episode shows from The Breakfast Club, beginning in 2016 and ending in May 2026. Chunks containing primarily advertising are not included. Bands represent the topic's share of the runtime each year, weighted by

duration, and the bands for one year each sum to 100 percent. Two shaded regions indicate data quality issues of note: the hatched region represents a low number of episodes and is excluded from analysis, and the grey bands represent 2021 and 2022, where lower-quality transcripts (SRTs) are concentrated as opposed to JSON, the gold standard of the project.

Structure: where political meaning sits

The second expectation, that politics lives in two distinct registers in different parts of the show, is evident before any of the national event analysis. From 2019 onward, with advertisement chunks excluded, ambient framing accounts for 28 percent of framed chunks in full shows, and Table VI.1 and Figure VI.2 show how the two registers distribute across topics. Politics-and-government content is 93 percent direct and 4.5 percent ambient, which makes it the home of the direct register and almost nothing else. Weighted by topic size, 58 percent of all direct framing sits in the politics topic. Ambient framing is the mirror image, with only about 7 percent of it in the politics topic and about 43 percent in crime and celebrity content. Crime is the one topic where ambient framing exceeds direct framing in absolute terms, at 29 against 21 percent of its chunks, and celebrity content is second, at 11 against 7 percent. Relationships-and-lifestyle content has the highest ambient share of any topic, at 62 percent of its framed chunks, but in small absolute numbers, so when the show's politics touches relationships it is almost always ambient, although it rarely does. Taken together, 44 percent of framed chunks on this base sit in the politics topic and 56 percent sit outside it, a gap Section VII takes up in full as the measurement cost of coding politics by topic.

Table VI.1. Direct and Ambient Framing by Primary Topic

Topic	Chunks	Direct (% of topic)	Ambient (% of topic)	Ambient share of framed
Politics & government	8,838	93.2	4.5	4.6
Crime & policing	3,960	21.1	29.0	57.9
Celebrity & entertainment	10,630	7.3	11.1	60.4
Sports	3,530	14.2	10.6	42.6
Business & economy	1,711	30.0	10.5	25.9
Health	1,056	28.2	11.0	28.0
Relationships & lifestyle	5,611	3.2	5.2	62.0
Music industry	8,592	5.9	5.8	49.6
Comedy & banter	17,071	11.7	6.4	35.2
Other	1,081	21.4	17.6	45.1

Note: Full shows, 2019 to May 2026, advertisement chunks excluded, with the chunk as the unit of analysis. The direct and ambient columns are the percentages of each topic's chunks carrying each register, and the final column is the ambient share of that topic's framed chunks. The average ambient share of framed chunks across all topics on this base is 28 percent.

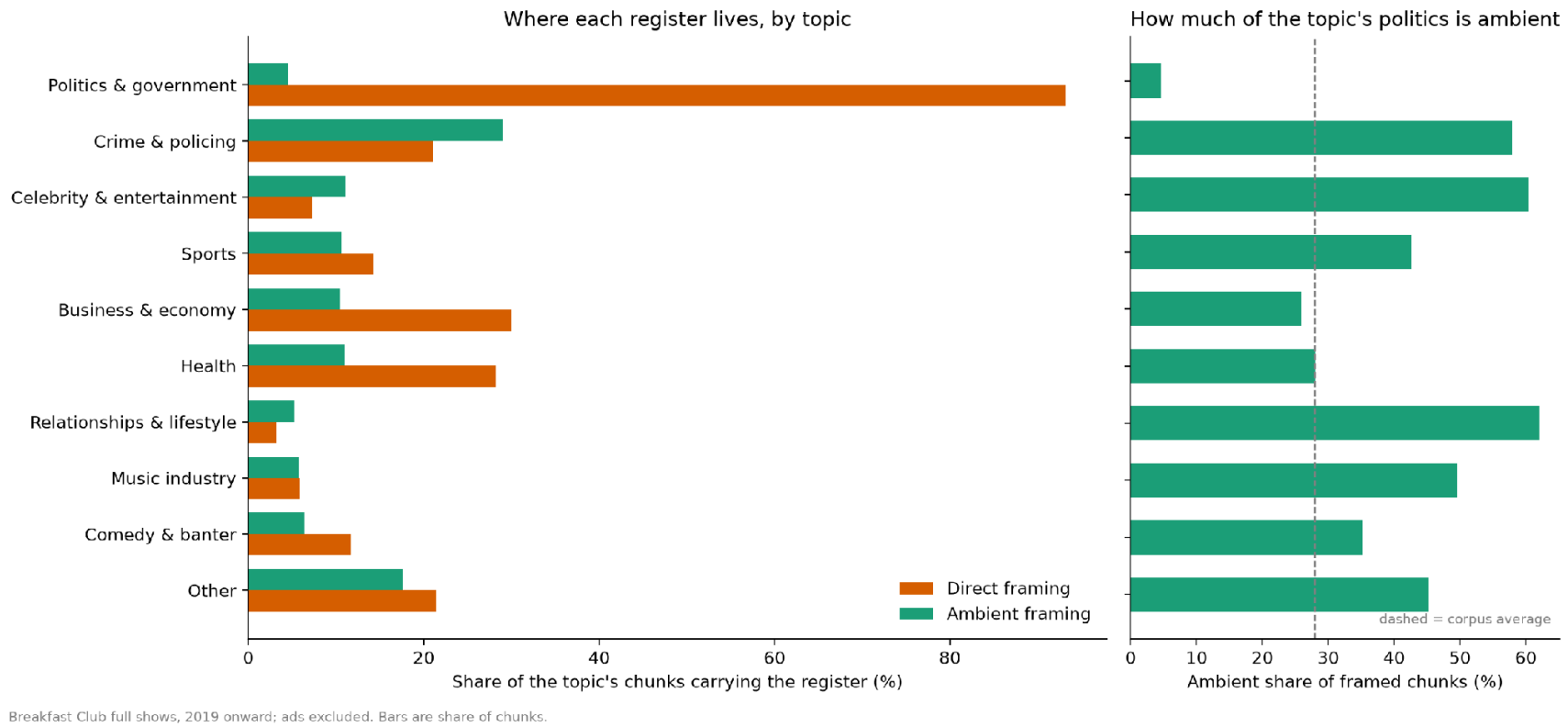


Figure VI.2. Direct and Ambient Framing by Topic.
Unit: Full shows from 2019 to May 2026, with advertisement chunks excluded. Left panel: the share of each topic's chunks carrying direct framing (orange) and ambient framing (green). Right panel: the ambient share of each topic's framed chunks, with the dashed line marking the all-topic average of 28 percent.

The ideological distribution differs by register as well, as Table VI.2 and Figure VI.3 show us how the ideological distribution differs across register, particularly within the broader corpus containing all dated non rerun episodes. Direct content skews liberal, with two-thirds of it falling between 1 and 3 on the seven-point scale. Ambient content sits at the midpoint 63 percent of the time and is more than twice as likely to be scored centrist as direct content is. Whether that pattern reflects ambient framing carrying political salience without ideological valence, or the model defaulting to the midpoint on content too subtle to place, is unresolved pending the reliability check and is stated as such.

Table VI.2. Ideology Score Distribution by Framing Register

Register	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	Mean	Median	n
Direct	9.6	39.9	18.2	26.2	3.0	2.9	0.1	2.82	3	30,731
Ambient	1.0	15.5	16.5	63.4	2.2	1.4	0.0	3.55	4	13,827

Note: All dated non-rerun episodes, 2014 to May 2026, with advertisement chunks and duplicate uploads excluded. The unit is the scored chunk; cells are percentages of each register's scored chunks at each point on a seven-point scale running from strongly liberal (1) through centrist (4) to strongly conservative (7). Chunks flagged as carrying political framing but lacking an ideology score are excluded (Section IV).

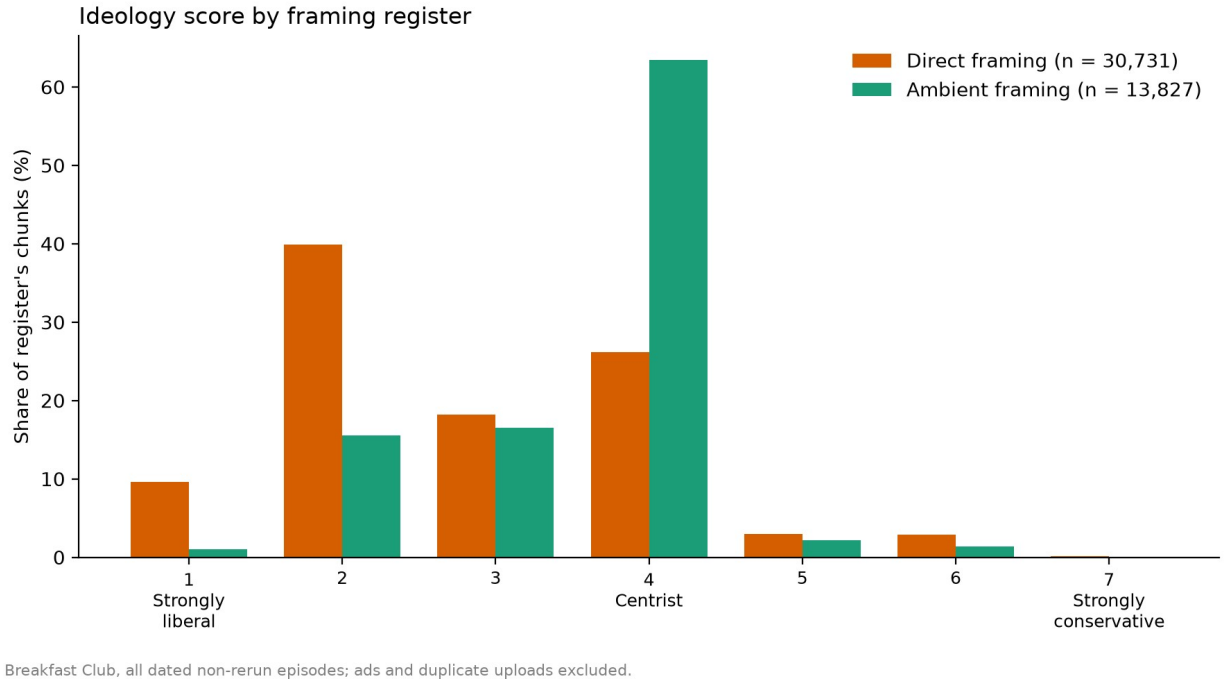


Figure VI.3. Ideology Score Distribution by Framing Register.
Unit: All dated non-rerun episodes, 2014 to May 2026, with advertisement chunks and duplicate uploads excluded. Each bar is the percentage of a register's scored chunks at that score, direct in orange (n = 30,731) and ambient in green (n = 13,827), on a scale running from strongly liberal (1) through centrist (4) to strongly conservative (7).

The structural evidence that direct framing is concentrated in the show's discussion of politics and ambient framing is clustered in discussion of crime and celebrity help to establish the premise tested in the subsequent sections. If the registers can change in quantity of content through different forces, the division between the registers is a feature of the show's production of political meaning and not simply an artifact of topic coverage.

Exploiting variation: what moves the two registers

While the analyses of composition and structure are descriptive, the following section asks what moves the show. By using two different sources of variation not controlled by the hosts, the timing of national events and the show's segment label, I exploit variation to show what causes the show to shift the framing register of its political discussion.

National shocks. I predict that direct framing should happen in response to the broader national news environment,while ambient framing should not. I also predict, following from Cohen's theory, that direct framing should respond more to consensus shocks and not cross-cutting ones (Cohen 1999). The George Floyd protests and the presidential elections are consensus shocks in this sense, the *Dobbs* decision is a cross-cutting one, and the COVID onset and the 2022 midterm serve as windows that fit neither category. Event windows were defined for the COVID onset from March 11 to April 30, 2020, the Floyd protests from May 25 to July 31, 2020, the 2020 and 2024 presidential run-ups from September 1 to November 30, the *Dobbs* decision from June 24 to August 31, 2022, and the 2022 midterm run-up from September 1 to November 30. Each window is compared with the rest of its own year on full shows from 2019 onward, with year fixed effects and standard errors clustered by episode, and Table VI.3 reports the results.

Table VI.3. Event-Window Estimates for Topic and Framing Outcomes

Window	Chunks	Politics topic	Direct present	Ambient present	Ambient share of framed
Presidential run-ups (2020, 2024)	4,453	+8.9***	+10.2***	−1.6*	−9.3***
Floyd protests	780	+7.4	+19.9**	−1.0	−12.2***
COVID onset	833	−0.4	−0.8	−6.6***	−15.6***
Dobbs	1,438	−1.1	−0.5	−0.3	−0.2
Midterm run-up (2022)	2,211	−1.3	+0.1	+0.6	+1.3

Note: Full shows, 2019 to May 2026, 62,080 chunks, advertisement chunks excluded. Each cell is the difference, in percentage points, between chunks inside the window and chunks in the rest of the same year; the chunk column counts chunks inside the window. The windows are the COVID onset, March 11 to April 30, 2020; the Floyd protests, May 25 to July 31, 2020; presidential run-ups, September 1 to November 30 of 2020 and 2024; *Dobbs*, June 24 to August 31, 2022; midterm run-up, September 1 to November 30, 2022. Estimates come from linear probability models with year fixed effects and standard errors clustered by episode, and the ambient-share column is estimated on framed chunks only. Estimates pooling standalone interviews with full shows are reported in the Robustness subsection, and full coefficient tables appear in Appendix C. * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$.

Every consensus shock aligns with a consistent pattern of pulling show into its direct register. Direct framing rises 10 points in presidential run-ups and 20 points during the Floyd protests, the largest effect in the table, and June 2020 is the peak month, with 63 percent of full-show chunks carrying direct framing. The politics-topic share during the Floyd window is positive but imprecise in full shows alone, at 7.4 points ($p = .12$), and it becomes clear once standalone interviews are pooled, which reflects the thin full-show count in mid-2020 rather than a difference in direction. In no months does ambient framing exceed 15 percent or drop below 4 percent, resisting spikes from the shock and actually dropping in proportion of content for every major shock window. Ambient framing does not rise with any shock, since in no month does it exceed 15 percent of chunks or fall below 4, and the ambient share of framed content falls in every major shock window. In June 2020, when 63 percent of chunks carried direct framing, ambient framing stood at 9 percent, within a point of its level in an ordinary month. I

argue that ambient framing is truly the show's baseline register, displaced by urgent politics rather than amplified. The midterm window is a clean null, with no effect on any outcome across 2,211 chunks, so the absence of movement is not a matter of statistical power.

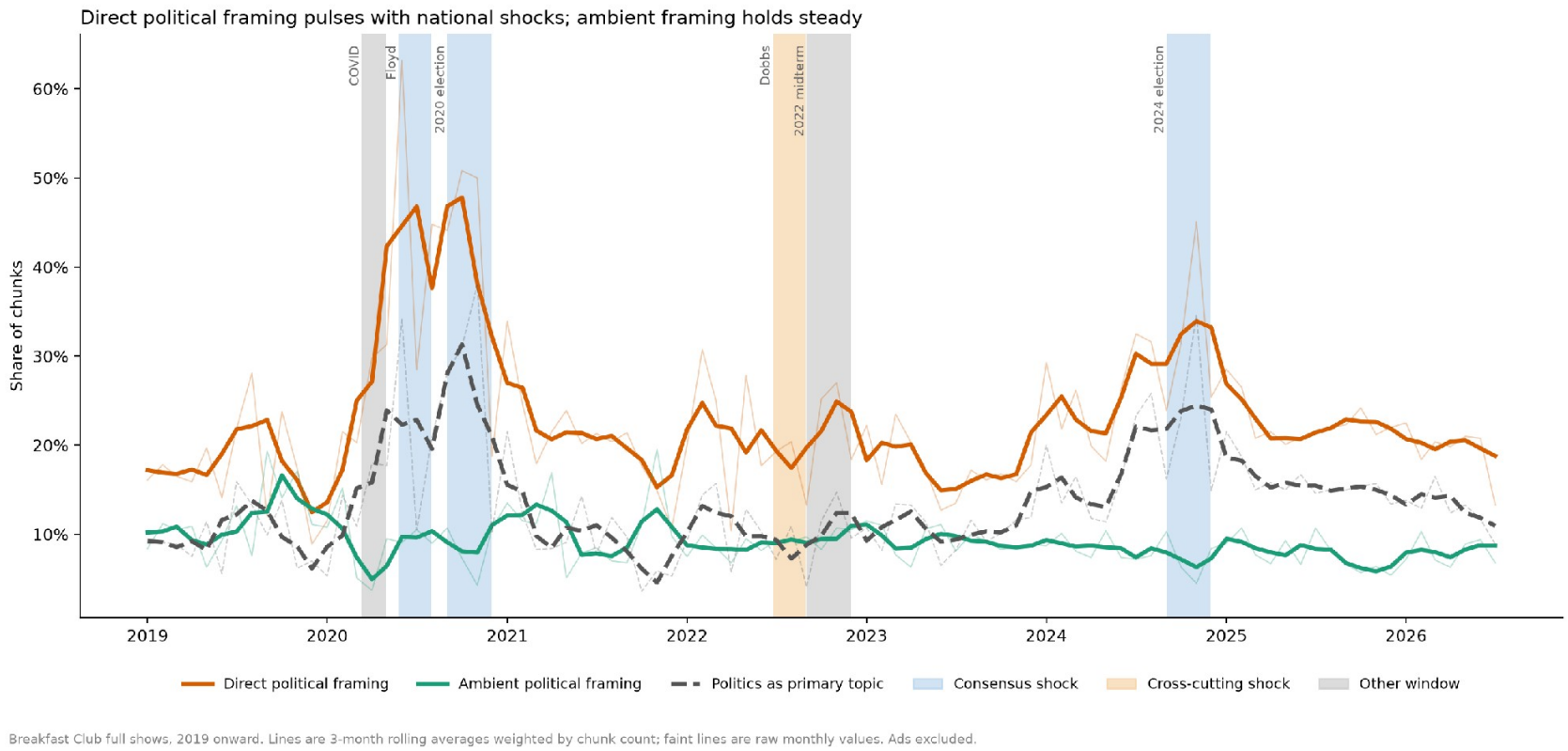


Figure VI.4. Monthly Direct, Ambient, and Politics-Topic Shares of Full-Show Chunks.
Unit: Full shows from 2019 to 2026, with advertisement chunks excluded. The unit is the chunk, and each line gives the share of a month's chunks carrying direct framing (orange), ambient framing (green), or politics and government as the primary topic (dashed grey). Bold lines are three-month centered rolling averages weighted by chunk count, and faint lines are raw monthly values. Shaded windows mark consensus shocks in blue (the Floyd protests and the 2020 and 2024 presidential run-ups), the cross-cutting *Dobbs* window in tan, and the other windows in grey (the COVID onset and the 2022 midterm run-up). The centered average spreads each spike into its neighboring months, so the regression estimates in Table VI.3, not the plotted lines, carry the claims about each window.

When the shock is broken down by topic, as Figure VI.5 shows, the source of these spikes becomes quite clear. The 2020 direct spike represents a combination of politics-topic, crime, and comedy content while the 2024 election spike is almost entirely politics-topic content. Direct framing also spreads into entertainment topics during shocks, with comedy-and-banter content rising from about 10 percent direct in ordinary months to 30 percent during the Floyd protests and the 2020 election and 22 percent in the 2024 run-up, and celebrity content reaching 37 percent direct during the Floyd protests, as the comedy and celebrity panels of Figure D.1 show, sharply illustrating the point of measurement outlined in Section VII. Contrastingly, ambient framing runs between 10 and 16 percent of chunks through 2019 and between 7 and 9 percent from 2021 onward, and although it stays within its band and never responds to a shock, the cause of that downward step after 2020 is not established here.

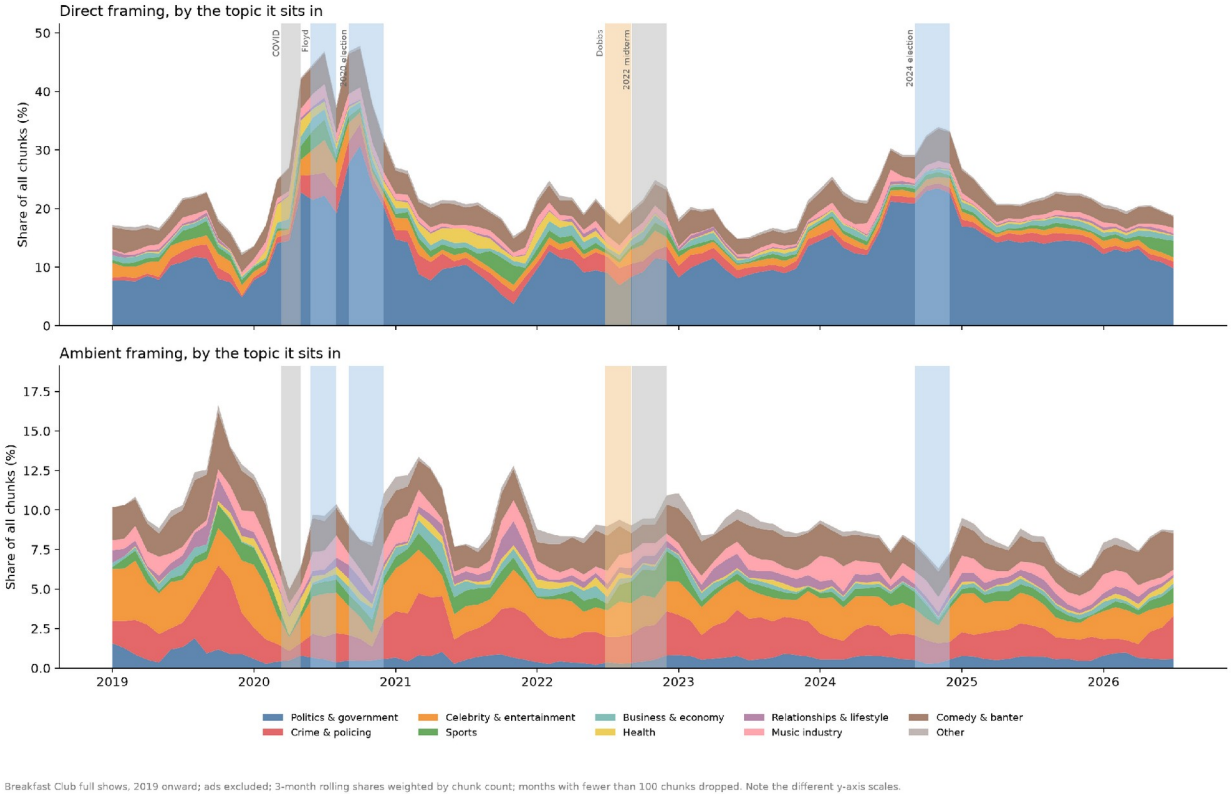


Figure VI.5. Direct and Ambient Framing by Topic, Monthly.
Unit: Full shows from 2019 to 2026, with advertisement chunks excluded. The unit is the chunk, and each band is the share of all full-show chunks in a month that carry the register and fall in that topic, so the height of each stack equals the register's total monthly share. Values are three-month centered rolling shares weighted by chunk count, and months with fewer than 100 chunks are dropped. The two panels use different vertical scales, and shaded windows follow the scheme in Figure VI.4.

Dobbs. While the show did directly discuss and engage the *Dobbs* decision that effectively overturned *Roe,* the null in Table VI.3 reflects how briefly it did so rather than an absence of coverage. In the week of the decision, abortion terms appear in 54 chunks across 8 of that week's 15 episodes, or 15.5 percent of the week's content, against about 4.7 percent in each of the two weeks after the May leak, but engagement fell back to between 1 and 2 percent within a week, which a ten-week window across 1,438 chunks in 35 episodes diluted into a null on every outcome. When the show did discuss *Dobbs*, it did so directly, since 97.3 percent of the 109

abortion chunks from the leak through August are flagged political, none of them ambient, with a mean ideology score of 2.26, a profile that matches the policing benchmark in 2020 at 99.5 percent framed, 7.2 percent ambient, and a mean score of 2.21. Abortion terms ran at 14.2 per 1,000 chunks in 2022 against 39.2 per 1,000 for policing terms in 2020, and they returned at 12.7 per 1,000 in 2024 as an election issue while running below 7 per 1,000 in every other year since 2016. The show's brief treatment of Dobbs as politics is a Cohen-compatible finding about the duration of attention to a cross-cutting issue, but it is not the ambient mechanism, and I do not claim it as one.

For the second and third expectations, the event windows give a consistent answer: the direct register moves with consensus shocks and the presidential calendar, and it holds still through a cross-cutting shock and a midterm. The ambient register moves with none of them, which is what the argument for two registers with different generators requires.

Format. My expectation that ambient framing should vary with show formatting is briefly outlined here as an exploratory result formed after the initial episode typology. These labels come from the show itself, and therefore are a natural test of whether political framing tracks across these shifts in format The fourth expectation, that ambient framing should vary with the show's own formats, was formed after the episode typology was built and is tested here as an exploratory result. Those labels are the show's own claims about what kind of content each segment is, which makes them a natural test of whether political framing tracks the label. Donkey of the Day is presented as comedic commentary, and its topic mix differs from that of the full show, with crime and policing making up 19.7 percent of its chunks against 6.4 percent in full shows, and comedy and banter 36.3 against 27.5 percent. The politics-and-government share is nearly identical, at 14.8 against 14.2 percent, so Donkey of the Day is not more political by topic, and the question is whether it is more politically framed once topic is held constant. Table VI.4 compares Donkey of the Day clips with full shows under three specifications: year fixed effects only, year and topic fixed effects, and year and topic fixed effects with the crime and celebrity categories dropped, since those are where the classifier's false positives concentrated.

Table VI.4. Donkey of the Day Clips Relative to Full Shows Under Three Specifications

Outcome	Year FE only	+ topic FE	+ topic FE, crime and celebrity dropped
Framing present	+7.7***	+1.3 (p = .10)	+3.3***
Ambient present	+4.5***	+1.9**	+3.1***
Ambient share of framed	+6.4***	+4.0**	+4.4***
Mean ideology (1–7), framed chunks	−0.23***	−0.21***	−0.27***

Note: Donkey of the Day clips and full shows, 2019 to May 2026, advertisement chunks excluded; standalone Donkey of the Day clips begin in 2022. Each cell is the difference between Donkey of the Day chunks and full-show chunks, in percentage points for the first three rows and in scale points for mean ideology on a seven-point scale running from strongly liberal (1) to strongly conservative (7). The first two rows are estimated on 107,722 chunks, or 82,923 in the third specification; the ambient-share row on 33,937 framed chunks; and the ideology row on 33,606 scored chunks. Estimates come from linear models with the fixed effects shown and standard errors clustered by episode; standalone interviews are estimated in the same models as a second comparison group, and with topic controls they show an ambient-present difference of +0.6 points (p = .04) and an ideology difference of −0.03 (not significant). * p < .05, ** p < .01, *** p < .001.

The higher overall framing rate of Donkey of the Day is primarily driven by topic selection, as it collapses after controlling for topic from 7.7 to 1.3 points. Its higher ambient framing rate is not,

because roughly half of the excess survives topic controls, and it grows rather than shrinks when the categories most exposed to classifier error are removed. Donkey of the Day's framed content is also more liberal by about a quarter of a scale point with topic held constant, and that effect is likewise larger in the third specification. One confound cannot be separated with this design: Donkey of the Day is Charlamagne's segment, so format and host are the same thing. The accurate claim is that one host's scripted commentary carries more ambient, more liberal political framing than the show's ensemble talk, holding topic and year constant, a point which tracks with Charlamagne's expanding political profile tracking the rise in popularity of the show (Los Angeles Times 2020).

No comparable effect extends to standalone interviews, reported in the note on Table VI.4. Other labeled segments, including Rumor Report, are too few as standalone episodes to support a separate comparison. For the fourth expectation, the format result places ambient framing inside the show's own production choices rather than in the news, which is where the argument for a register belonging to the show locates it, with the caveat that the format and the host cannot yet be told apart.

Robustness

Pooling standalone interviews with full shows, with a product-type fixed effect, reproduces the event-window pattern in Table VI.3. In the pooled sample, presidential run-ups raise the politics-topic share by 7.1 points and direct framing by 8.1 points (both $p < .001$), and the Floyd protests raise them by 8.9 and 19.5 points (both $p < .001$) while lowering the ambient share of framed content by 7.2 points ($p < .01$). The COVID onset, the *Dobbs* window, and the midterm run-up remain null on both the politics-topic share and direct framing. The one departure is a small rise in ambient framing present during the Floyd protests in the pooled sample, at 2.3 points ($p = .04$), which is why the paper describes the ambient level as stable across shocks rather than as falling.

VII. Discussion

Across the analyses, the evidence supports an account of the venue as a political institution, with the exceptions noted below. I find that direct framing rises in the context of presidential elections and the 2020 George Floyd protests, while not shifting in response to the 2022 midterm or *Dobbs* decision. Furthermore, political elites arrive in a surge in the 30 days directly preceding presidential elections, on the same calendar that emphasizes a rise in direct political content. The same surge does not appear before midterms. Potentially, midterms are just not salient enough to prompt a visit to more niche platforms, or are a neglected element of overall party and candidate strategy. These arrivals are marked by a shift into the direct register. Ambient framing holds within a narrow band across seven years, does not rise with any of the shocks that move direct framing, and varies instead with the show's own marked segment formats. The vast majority of political content on the show is happening when no political guest is present; a traditional coding of political content by topic alone would capture fewer than half of the broader political content captured in this typology, further outlined in the measurement discussion below. My analysis shows that *The Breakfast Club* is a political institution that runs on its own register. Rather than briefly turning into campaign stops when political elites are around, politicians are entering a constantly political venue at decisive moments, and shifting them into the register of conventional politics. What traditional measures would simply write

off as entertainment media actually contains significant political meaning; rather than viewing gossip and entertainment platforms as separate from or inferior to traditional political media, these findings suggest they are central to how Black political discourse functions today. The direct register is beholden to the news cycle and election calendar, but the ambient register is the heartbeat of the show that requires our further analysis and deepened understanding.

The pattern has exceptions, and they limit how far it can be pushed. Ambient framing fell sharply at the onset of COVID and stepped down after 2020 for reasons this paper cannot establish, so its stability is relative rather than absolute. In the pooled sample, ambient framing rose slightly during the Floyd protests, by 2.3 points. The move into the direct register when politicians appear is also not unique to politicians: activists and commentators produce nearly the same shift, so what distinguishes elites is when they come, not the register they bring. And the format result cannot separate Donkey of the Day from its host; the defensible claim is that one host's scripted commentary carries more ambient framing than the show's ensemble talk.

The data gestures towards an important point of comparison on issues beyond the scope of this paper. Table VII.1 reports keyword sets for three issues across the corpus and how issues may shift in register and ideology.

Table VII.1. Framing of Keyword Chunks by Issue

Keyword set	Chunks	Episodes	Politics topic	Framed	Ambient share of framed	Mean ideology, framed
Policing, 2020	403	101	54.6%	99.5%	7.2%	2.21
Abortion, May–Aug 2022	109	37	67.0%	97.3%	0.0%	2.26
Sexuality terms, all years	4,501	1,816	12.5%	39.4%	40.3%	3.18
All chunks, reference	118,631	4,158	13.8%	31.3%	29.7%	3.04

Note: Chunks containing terms from each keyword set, with reruns and cross-posts excluded. The sexuality set is restricted to 2019 onward to match the event-window sample, and the abortion and policing rows are drawn from the full dated corpus. The politics-topic and framed columns are percentages of each set's chunks; the ambient share is the percentage of framed chunks carrying ambient framing; mean ideology is on a seven-point scale from strongly liberal (1) to strongly conservative (7). The ideology column is confounded with the register, since ambient chunks cluster at the midpoint, and it is held pending the reliability check.

This initial foray into keyword-in-context analysis shows that policing and abortion arrive on the show as politics and are framed directly, while sexuality is primarily discussed as celebrity content, flagged as political less than half the time, and more often framed ambiently than either of these other issues. Keyword searches are biased toward direct talk, since naming an issue is itself a direct act, which makes this sexuality contrast conservative.

A brief analysis of two entertainment-originated controversies involving sexuality, rapper DaBaby's remarks at Rolling Loud in July 2021 and the release of Dave Chappelle's *The Closer* in October 2021, point the same way, since sexuality terms rose by 2.2 and 3.2 points in the four weeks after each while direct framing did not move, and these windows are reported as illustrations with full estimates in Appendix C.

A reading of the sexuality chunks shows that the current classifier catches sexuality when it is attached to a public controversy with institutional stakes, such as a brand dropping an artist or an organization calling on a platform, and misses it when the show sets norms in its own voice about what men do and who belongs. The second category is the mechanism Cohen's framework predicts, and future work can measure it with a targeted classifier for norm-setting

statements that captures how that talk is bounded (Cohen 1999). I report the contrast as a pointer to that work rather than as a finding.

The analyses of the paper provide key evidence and historical record of the migration of the everyday talk phenomenon studied in *Barbershops, Bibles, and BET* (Harris-Lacewell 2004). The theory of everyday talk is now tested against the spoken word itself, and still operating to a large audience and at the national level. My findings in the census and content analysis work in conjunction to describe a public moving through the modes of address outlined by Squires, speaking in their own register primarily and shifting to the legibility of national politics when elites arrive at the show (Squires 2002). Further, Cohen's distinction between consensus and cross-cutting issues, developed to explain institutional behavior, predicts whether the show's direct register responds to a national event: it did for Floyd and presidential elections and did not for *Dobbs* (Cohen 1999).

I put myself in conversation with the frameworks of communication scholars that sharply divide the media environment between entertainment and news, particularly as it relates to Black media (Kim 2023). I propose the modest modification that a distribution of political meaning may occur in a hybrid stream as opposed to simply leakage across the political and entertainment boundaries. The findings suggest that these responses to different sources of variation are not noise around a single political signal, but two distinct signals with different generators, and should be modeled in further accounts of hybridized media.

If I had only analyzed political content by topic, I would have found roughly 10 percent of the show's full-show runtime in an ordinary year and up to 19 percent in an election year to be political content. A content analysis that codes for framing regardless of topic finds that 29 percent of the show's chunks, advertisements excluded, carry political meaning, and more than half of that framed content, 56 percent on the full-show base, sits in content a topic coder would have discarded. The gap between the directly and ambiently political represents a gap in what the field has been measuring and what our audiences are actually hearing. When compounded with our underestimation of reach across format, traditional topic based measures may miss much of the politics audiences are receiving and undercount them more than once.

The paper is limited by the single case, and that the survival of one outlet to have a record this long is not drawn randomly from Black media, but endogenous. The reliability check against human coding is outstanding. The results surround shifts in formatting and the transcripts themselves cannot investigate how the difference in content is driven by different hosts. The census understates elite use through excluding campaign surrogates and primaries. Perhaps most pressing is a comparator outlet with which to set the show's patterns against.

As the nature of this paper is descriptive and structural, I limit my claims to the supply side of political meaning and identifying what may move the show's framing. The design cannot support claims that ambient framing moves attitudes or that exposure to the show changes behavior, and the paper makes none. The show's political content also sits left of center, and ambient content is scored at the ideological midpoint far more often than direct content, but the paper holds that result until human coding can say whether the midpoint reflects the content or the coder. Further work will directly engage the effects the content has upon listeners.

My subsequent work seeks to investigate these limitations in turn, beginning with the reliability check. I will potentially follow with a matched comparison of the same guests on this show and on mainstream outlets in the same week, providing the missing comparator while holding the moment and candidate constant. Perhaps centrally and of personal importance, the analysis of the subsequent work on sexuality will tackle Cohen's historical framework and place it along the boundary where she situates it and is most visible, asking how the ambient register handles LGBTQIA+ Black Americans. The paper is merely the first step amongst a broader research agenda addressing the field's vital need to assess Black entertainment media's role as a political institution and within Black political life.

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Appendix A. Prompt Catalog

A.1 Purpose and conventions

This appendix records every prompt used to generate the classification data in the paper, because prompt wording is the measurement instrument in a large language model content analysis and a result reported without its instrument cannot be replicated. Each entry gives the model, the status of the prompt, and its verification status. Prompts marked VERBATIM were recovered in full from working sessions; prompts marked PARTIAL were recovered without their opening line, which is marked in the text. The prompts appear exactly as run, including the classifier’s own vocabulary.

Naming. The framing classifier passed through a pilot design and one revision. The pilot, which assigned a single political, entertainment, or mixed label, is Phase 1 and was replaced before any reported result. The two-field instrument used for every reported result is Phase 2, and its two versions are Phase 2, Version 1 and Phase 2, Version 2. The main text refers to these as Version 1 and Version 2 and describes the classifier as revised once.

Terminology. The Phase 2, Version 2 prompt records the basis of political framing as `explicit` or `implicit`. These values operationalize the paper's direct and ambient registers respectively, and the paper uses direct and ambient everywhere except in the verbatim prompts below.

A.2 Stage A: Corpus assembly and metadata join

Stage A involves no model, and in it transcripts were loaded, segmented into 179,438 chunks of approximately 2,000 characters aligned to transcript segment boundaries, and joined to episode metadata, including titles and publication dates, from a separate CSV keyed on episode identifier.

A.3 Stage B, Phase 1: Political, entertainment, or mixed label (pilot)

Model: claude-haiku-4-5-20251001. **Status:** Superseded at pilot; not used for any reported result. **Verification:** PARTIAL, opening line not recovered.

```
Classify the following text as one of:
"political", "entertainment", or "mixed" (entertainment content with
embedded
political framing).

Respond with only a JSON object: {"label": "...", "confidence": 0-1}

TEXT:
{text}
```

The pilot was replaced because a single three-way label forced the topic and framing onto one dimension. A celebrity story framed through policing language is both a celebrity story and a politically framed one, and a "mixed" label discards which of the two facts is being recorded; the design also placed all nonpolitical content in one category, which made topic composition unmeasurable.

A.4 Stage B, Phase 2, Version 1: Topic and political framing

Model: claude-haiku-4-5-20251001. **Status:** Superseded for the framing field; the topic labels from this run remain in use. **Verification:** PARTIAL, opening line not recovered.

The topic typology has eleven categories: `politics_government`, `crime_policing`, `celebrity_entertainment`, `sports`, `business_economy`, `health`, `relationships_lifestyle`, `music_industry`, `comedy_banter`, `advertisement`, and `other`.

```
[opening line not recovered] Classify the
following text on two independent dimensions:

1. primary_topic: the single best-fitting topic from this list:
{topics}
2. political_framing_present: true if the segment invokes political,
civil-rights,
```

```
   or policy-adjacent framing regardless of its primary topic (e.g. a
sports segment
   discussing athlete activism, or a celebrity story framed through
policing and race,
   should be marked true even though its primary_topic is not
politics_government);
   false if the segment is purely descriptive or apolitical.

Respond with only a JSON object:
{"primary_topic": "...", "political_framing_present": true/false,
"confidence": 0-1}

TEXT:
{text}
```

Topic and framing are recorded as independent fields, which is what allows a chunk to be coded as celebrity content while also carrying political framing. Advertisement is its own category, excluded from topic-composition denominators and reported separately as a share of runtime. This version flagged 69,826 chunks as carrying political framing. Its framing field was superseded after a manual audit found a false positive rate of roughly 25 percent, concentrated in neutral procedural recaps of celebrity legal proceedings.

A.5 Stage B, Phase 2, Version 2: Political framing and its basis (current)

Model: claude-haiku-4-5-20251001. **Status:** Current; every reported framing and ideology result uses this version. **Verification:** VERBATIM. **Run:** Full-corpus recheck of all 179,438 chunks.

```
Does the following media content carry political, civil-rights,
or policy-relevant framing? This includes both explicit commentary
(naming a policy,
politician, or taking a stated position) and implicit framing
(language, tone, or
narrative choices that invoke racialized policing, systemic injustice,
or group-based
political meaning without stating it directly).

Mark political_framing_present FALSE for:
- Descriptive coverage of a celebrity's individual legal proceedings
(arrests, trials,
  courtroom procedure) with no commentary on policing, the justice
system, or policy,
  and no implicit racialized/systemic framing either — e.g. a neutral
play-by-play of
  a celebrity's court hearing.
- A politician mentioned only as a punchline or incidental reference
in an unrelated
  story (sports, celebrity news, personal anecdote), with no framing
attached.
```

```
Mark political_framing_present TRUE, and set basis to "explicit", for:
- Commentary that takes a position on policy, legislation, or a
systemic issue.
- Discussion of policing, race, or the justice system as a systemic or
civil-rights
  issue.
- Content about elected officials/elections engaging with their
positions or stakes.

Mark political_framing_present TRUE, and set basis to "implicit", for:
- A crime or police story where the language, tone, or framing evokes
racialized
  policing narratives (e.g. sympathetic treatment of someone framed by
hosts as
  unfairly targeted, emphasis on race in a police encounter) without
explicit
  policy commentary.
- Content about a public figure whose significance to the story is
tied to a
  politically-charged identity (race, sexuality, immigration status)
even if that
  identity is never named directly.

EXAMPLES:
- "A judge dismissed a juror in Diddy's trial today, here's the
timeline" -> FALSE
  (neutral procedural coverage, no framing of any kind)
- "25 years is too long for a 17-year-old who did a home invasion,
here's why" ->
  TRUE, explicit (juvenile sentencing policy commentary)
- Hosts sympathetically recap a Black public figure's arrest,
emphasizing the
  officers' aggression without ever using the words "police" or "race"
-> TRUE,
  implicit (racialized policing framing present in tone/emphasis, not
stated)
- "Kandi Burruss talks about her divorce settlement" -> FALSE (no
framing, explicit
  or implicit)
- "Biden's handling of migrant children is no better than Trump's" ->
TRUE, explicit

Respond with only a JSON object, no code fences, no extra text:
{"political_framing_present": true/false, "basis":
"explicit"/"implicit"/"none",
"reasoning": "one sentence"}

TEXT:
{text}
```

Version 2 made two changes, in that it tightened the boundary by naming the neutral procedural case as unframed, and it added the basis field, which is not a diagnostic but the measurement of the direct and ambient distinction on which the paper's theory rests. Under this version, 51,006 chunks carry political framing, 28.4 percent of the full corpus including advertisements. The 27 percent reduction from Version 1 is close to the hand-estimated false positive rate, which is consistent with the correction but does not validate Version 2; the reliability check in Stage E is designed to do that. When the corpus was reclassified, chunks that lost political status had their ideology scores cleared and chunks that gained it were sent for fresh scoring.

A.6 Stage C: Ideology scoring

Model: claude-sonnet-5. **Status:** Current for the prompt as run; results pending reliability validation. **Gate:** the framing flag from Stage B is true, independent of topic. **Verification:** VERBATIM.

```
Rate the ideological position expressed or implied in this media
content on a 7-point scale, where 1 = strongly liberal, 4 =
centrist/no clear lean,
7 = strongly conservative. Base this on framing, sourcing, and
language choices,
not on the topic itself.

Think through your answer silently. Do not narrate your reasoning, do
not say
"wait" or "let me reconsider," do not show a draft answer. Output only
the final
JSON object and nothing else.

{"score": 1-7, "rationale": "one sentence"}

TEXT:
{text}
```

The seven-point scale mirrors the self-placement conventions of the American National Election Studies, a convention adopted at design time rather than derived from the corpus. The prompt's second paragraph was added after the model narrated its self-corrections in an earlier stage and consumed output length; it changes the format of the response, not the judgment requested. Scoring is gated on framing rather than topic, so a sports segment that turns to athlete activism is scored while a descriptive recap of an election result is not. Scored on Version 1 framing input, the distribution was 42.2 percent liberal, 53.6 percent centrist, and 4.2 percent conservative across 69,290 scored chunks; on Version 2 input it is 54.9 percent liberal and 40.2 percent centrist, a shift of about thirteen points that shows prompt quality to be load-bearing for every downstream claim.

A.7 Elite census: model-assisted pre-coding

I hand coded the census of political elite appearances contained in Section V from episode titles, metadata, and the opening segments of transcripts. For lower-priority candidate episodes, a

model proposed coding decisions before review, and every proposal was reviewed and confirmed by hand. After review, 59 rows had blank required fields filled from the model's proposals, and the prompt text for this pass was not retained.

A.8 Stages designed but not yet run

Stage D, valence coding for sexuality. A valence scale for framed chunks discussing sexuality was designed, with a proposed range from −2 to +2, and is gated on the reliability check because it depends on the same register judgment that Stage E validates. **Stage E, reliability check.** A human-coded sample stratified by transcript format (JSON or SRT) and by framing register (direct, ambient, or none) has been drawn but not yet coded; it will report agreement on the framing flag and a confusion matrix for the eleven-category topic label rather than a single agreement statistic across both.

Appendix B. Census Flow and Exclusion Log

Figure B.1 traces each candidate episode from review to the final census, and Table B.1 lists every excluded episode with the reason recorded at review.

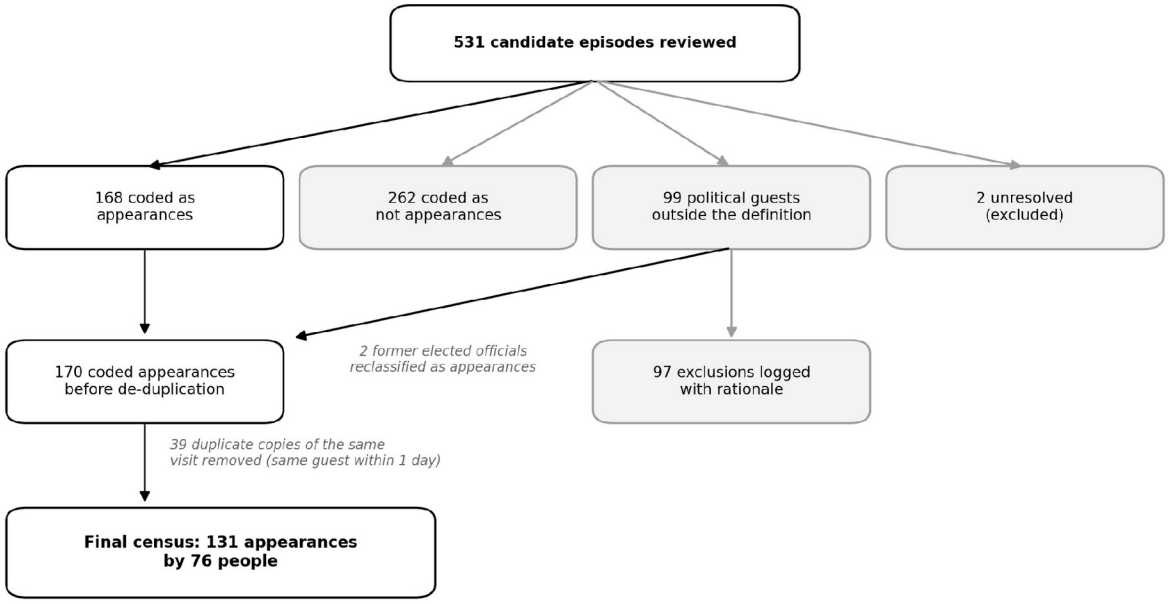


Figure B.1. Flow of Candidate Episodes Through the Census of Political Elite Appearances.
Unit: Candidate episodes of *The Breakfast Club*, April 2015 to May 2026. Of 531 candidate episodes reviewed, 168 were coded as appearances, 262 as not appearances, 99 as political guests outside the census definition, and 2 as unresolved. Two episodes first coded as outside the definition were reclassified as appearances under the rule that former elected officials count in any capacity, giving 170 coded appearances, and 97 exclusions remain logged with a rationale. Removing 39 duplicate copies of the same visit, defined as the same guest within one day, leaves a final census of 131 appearances by 76 people. Black outlines trace the path to the census; grey outlines mark episodes that leave it.

Table B.1. Census Exclusion Log

#	Air date	Guest	Reason for exclusion
1	2017-03-17	Valeisha Butterfield Jones	Former campaign/administration staffer (National Youth Vote Director) and Google executive, not an elected or high-level appointed official
2	2017-09-13	Eboni K Williams	Media personality/political commentator, not an elected or appointed official
3	2018-01-12	G-Eazy	Celebrity musician, not a political elite
4	2018-01-31	Angela Rye	Political commentator/media personality, not an elected or appointed official or party official
5	2018-08-16	Angela Rye	Political commentator/attorney, not an elected or appointed official or candidate
6	2018-12-07	April Ryan	She is a journalist/White House correspondent, not a political officeholder or candidate.
7	2019-07-12	Bill Bellamy	Comedian/actor, not a political elite
8	2019-07-18	Dr. Frederick Douglas Haynes III	Pastor and civic activist, not an elected/appointed official or candidate
9	2019-09-30	Forest Whitaker	Actor/celebrity, not a political elite
10	2020-02-11	Angela Rye	Political commentator/attorney, not an elected or appointed official
11	2020-04-02	Pastor John Gray	Religious leader/pastor, not a political elite
12	2020-05-07	DL Hughley	Comedian/media personality, not a political elite
13	2020-05-13	Nicky Jam	Musician/celebrity, not a political elite
14	2020-06-24	Wes Moore	Nonprofit CEO/author/social entrepreneur, not an elected or appointed political official or candidate at time of appearance
15	2020-10-23	Alicia Garza	Co-founder of Black Lives Matter movement; activist, not an elected/appointed official or candidate.
16	2020-10-23	Angela Rye	Political commentator/attorney, not a current or former elected official.
17	2021-02-19	Audrey Jackson	Private citizen (Pop Smoke's mother), not a political elite
18	2021-05-11	Tamika Mallory	Activist/civil rights organizer, not a political elite (no elected/appointed office).
19	2021-11-03	Ari Melber	Political journalist/commentator (MSNBC anchor), not an elected or appointed official
20	2022-04-07	Quinta Brunson	Celebrity/TV creator, not a political elite
21	2022-07-06	Damson Idris	Celebrity actor, not a political elite
22	2022-07-06	Viola Davis	Celebrity actress, not a political elite
23	2022-10-25	April Ryan	Journalist/commentator, not a political officeholder or candidate
24	2023-03-03	Angela Rye	Political commentator/analyst delivering news segment, not a political officeholder or candidate
25	2023-10-02	Erica Ford	Head of a community violence-intervention nonprofit (activist/organization leader), not a political elite
26	2024-01-11	Angela Rye	Political commentator/activist, not an elected or appointed official
27	2024-01-11	Tiffany Cross	Media commentator/journalist, not a political elite
28	2024-01-18	Piers Morgan	Media commentator/journalist, not a political elite
29	2024-02-27	Michael Harriot	Journalist/author/political commentator, not a political elite
30	2024-03-21	Candace Owens	Political commentator/media figure, not an elected official, candidate, or party official
31	2024-03-25	Derrick Dowdell	Personal trainer, not a political figure
32	2024-03-29	Oleyimika Oluwaseun (Yimme Olurin)	Described as an activist and political commentator, not an elected or appointed official.
33	2024-04-12	Michael Eric Dyson	Academic, author, and political commentator, not an elected/appointed official or candidate
34	2024-04-16	Molina Abdullah	VP running mate for a non-major-party presidential ticket, primarily known as BLM activist, not a serious campaign officeholder
35	2024-05-07	Jonathan Karl	Journalist/political commentator, not an elected or appointed official
36	2024-05-08	Angela Rye	Political commentator/activist, not an elected or appointed official
37	2024-05-08	Angela Rye	Political commentator/activist, not an officeholder or candidate.
38	2024-07-22	Angela Rye	Political commentator/analyst, not a candidate or officeholder
39	2024-08-06	Rashad Bilal	Podcast host/entrepreneur, not a political elite
40	2024-08-06	Troy Millings	Podcast host/entrepreneur, not a political elite
41	2024-08-07	Jessica Tarlov	Political commentator/TV host, not an elected or appointed official or candidate
42	2024-08-13	Vivek Ramaswamy	Former presidential candidate appearing as campaign surrogate

#	Air date	Guest	Reason for exclusion
43	2024-08-23	Isaac Hayes III	Estate manager/entrepreneur, not a political elite
44	2024-08-23	James Walker Jr.	Attorney, not a political elite
45	2024-08-28	Angelo Pinto	Attorney/activist-in-residence, not a political elite
46	2024-08-28	Tamika D. Mallory	Activist/co-founder of Until Freedom, not a political elite
47	2024-09-11	Angela Rye	Political commentator/attorney, not an elected or appointed official or candidate
48	2024-09-11	Tiffany Cross	Political commentator/journalist, not an elected or appointed official or candidate
49	2024-09-16	Michael Eric Dyson	Academic/author/political commentator, not an elected or appointed official or candidate
50	2024-10-14	Robert Kraft	Businessman/NFL owner and philanthropist, not a candidate or officeholder
51	2024-12-02	Erricka Bridgeford	Community activist/organizer, not a political elite
52	2025-01-03	Tezlyn Figaro	Political commentator/organizer, not a candidate or officeholder
53	2025-01-03	Tezlyn Figaro	Political commentator/strategist, not an elected or appointed official or candidate
54	2025-02-17	Derrick Johnson	Head of civil rights organization (NAACP), not a political elite
55	2025-02-17	Scott Mills	Head of advocacy organization (HRC), not a political elite
56	2025-03-10	Andrew Schulz	Comedian/celebrity, not a political elite
57	2025-04-02	Al Sharpton	Civil rights activist and head of National Action Network, not a candidate or officeholder
58	2025-04-03	Elie Mystal	Political commentator/journalist, not a candidate or officeholder
59	2025-04-04	John Hope Bryant	Financial literacy activist/entrepreneur and presidential advisor, not an elected/appointed official or candidate
60	2025-04-16	Tezlyn Figaro	Political commentator/activist and media correspondent, not an elected/appointed official or current candidate
61	2025-04-28	Cenk Uygur	Media commentator/activist, not a candidate or officeholder
62	2025-05-22	(name not recorded)	Reason not recorded in review
63	2025-05-30	Tomi Lahren	Media/political commentator, not a candidate or officeholder
64	2025-07-17	Angela Rye	Political commentator/activist (attorney, media commentator), not an elected/appointed official or candidate
65	2025-07-17	Angela Rye	Political commentator/activist (former CBC Foundation exec, State of the People Tour organizer), not an elected or appointed official.
66	2025-08-12	Katrina Brownlee	Author and former police officer, not a political elite
67	2025-09-11	Mehdi Hasan	Journalist/commentator, not a political elite
68	2025-09-11	Mehdi Hassan	Journalist/author/commentator, not a political officeholder or candidate
69	2025-09-15	Nick Cannon	Entertainer/celebrity, not a political elite
70	2025-10-14	Angela Rye	Political commentator/attorney, not an elected or appointed official
71	2025-10-14	Tiffany Cross	Media personality/political commentator, not an elected or appointed official
72	2026-02-18	Flame Monroe	Comedian/actor/celebrity, not a political elite
73	2026-03-23	Dr. Umar Johnson	Activist/educator/public figure, not an elected or appointed official or candidate
74	2026-03-27	Tim Shriver	Head of Special Olympics/nonprofit advocacy leader, not a political officeholder or candidate
75	2026-03-27	Tim Shriver	Nonprofit/advocacy leader (Special Olympics chairman), not an elected or appointed government official
76	2026-04-03	John Hope Bryant	Business/civil rights entrepreneur and author, not a political elite
77	2026-05-08	Dana White	Business executive/celebrity, not a political elite
78	2026-07-15	Ashley Etienne	Former political staffer/advisor now working as media commentator (NBC contributor, consulting firm CEO), not a sitting or former elected/appointed official at cabinet level
79	—	Abby Phillip	Journalist/TV host, not a political elite
80	—	Abby Phillip	Journalist/TV anchor, not a political elite
81	—	Andrew Schulz	Comedian/celebrity, not a political elite
82	—	Ashley Allison	Former campaign staffer now serving as political commentator/activist, not a current elected/appointed official or candidate
83	—	Ava DuVernay	Filmmaker/celebrity guest, not a political elite
84	—	Ben Crump	Civil rights attorney/activist, not an elected or appointed official or candidate
85	—	Brian Grazer	Film producer/celebrity, not a political elite

#	Air date	Guest	Reason for exclusion
86	—	Emma Grede	Business entrepreneur (SKIMS co-founder), not a political figure
87	—	Jake Steinfeld	Celebrity fitness entrepreneur who considered but explicitly declined to run for office; not a candidate or officeholder.
88	—	Jalen Rose	Former NBA player and media personality, not a political elite
89	—	Jonathan Karl	Political journalist/author, not a political elite per inclusion criteria.
90	—	Joy-Ann Reid	Political commentator/journalist (host of The Joy Reid Show, former MSNBC anchor), not an elected/appointed official or candidate.
91	—	Knowa De Baraso	Political commentator/podcaster, not an officeholder or candidate for public office
92	—	Knowa De Baraso	Teen podcast host/media personality, not a political elite (candidate/officeholder/party official)
93	—	Mehdi Hasan	Journalist/media commentator, not a political elite
94	—	Michael 'Harry O' Harris	Entrepreneur/community activist, not an elected/appointed official or candidate for public office
95	—	Pinky Cole	Business entrepreneur/celebrity, not a political elite
96	—	Swae Lee	Celebrity musician, not a political elite
97	—	Young M.A	Musician/celebrity, not a political elite

Note: Political guests reviewed for the census of political elite appearances on *The Breakfast Club*, April 2015 to May 2026, and excluded under the census definition in Section V: 97 exclusions covering 87 episodes and 72 guests, since some episodes carried more than one excluded guest and some guests were excluded more than once. Each reason is the one-line rationale recorded at review, reproduced as written. Air dates are episode publication dates joined from episode-level files, because the exclusions table itself records only guest, episode, and reason; 19 rows whose dates could not be recovered from those files are marked with a dash and listed last.

Table B.2. Census Codebook

Variable	Definition	Type and allowed values	Values observed (n = 131)
Episode	Corpus identifier of the episode containing the appearance	String; required	131 rows
Air date	Publication date of the episode	Date	April 9, 2015 to May 12, 2026
Transcript source	Transcript format from which the air date was taken	json, srt, or missing if the air date is unknown	json (131)
Guest name	Name of the political guest	String; required	76 distinct people
Jurisdiction level	Level of the guest's jurisdiction on the air date	national, state, or district	national (45), state (33), district (52), missing (1)
Jurisdiction	The guest's jurisdiction on the air date, such as a state abbreviation or district code	String	String
Inclusion category	Guest's status on the air date	Closed set; required	candidate (58), sitting elected official (42), former elected official (17), appointed official (8), former appointed official (3), party official (3)
Nearest relevant election	Nearest federal or statewide election in the guest's jurisdiction, the default definition of the relevant election for a guest not personally on a ballot	Date	Date
Days to election	Days from the air date to the nearest relevant election, negative when the appearance precedes the election	Signed integer	−341 to 363
Race type	Type of the nearest relevant election	Free text	federal general (126), statewide general (5)
Primary or general	Whether the nearest relevant election is a primary or a general election	primary or general	general (131)

Variable	Definition	Type and allowed values	Values observed (n = 131)
Office level	Level of office at stake in the nearest relevant election	Free text	federal (126), statewide (5)
Election cycle	Election cycle label	Free text	2024 presidential (56), 2018 midterm (21), 2020 presidential (20), 2022 midterm (16), 2026 midterm (8), 2016 presidential (4), 2025 off-year (4), 2014 midterm (1), 2021 off-year (1)
Guest on the ballot	Whether the guest was a candidate in the nearest relevant election, recorded for every row so timing can be computed relative to the guest's own race or the nearest relevant election	Boolean; required	true (54), false (77)
Party	Guest's party on the air date	Free text	Democratic (119), Republican (8), Independent (4)
Held office at appearance	Whether the guest held office on the air date	Boolean; required	true (82), false (49)
Segment type	Whether the appearance was a solo interview or part of a larger segment	solo interview or part of larger segment; required	solo interview (118), part of larger segment (13)
Duration (minutes)	Length of the appearance in minutes	Decimal	16.8 to 111.9 (84 coded; 47 missing)
Duration source	Source of the duration measure	srt or hand_estimate	srt (84), missing (47)
During an announced campaign	Whether the appearance fell during the guest's announced campaign	Boolean; required	true (67), false (64)

Note: Census of political elite appearances on *The Breakfast Club*, April 2015 to May 2026. Each row of the appearances table is one appearance, so a guest who appeared three times contributes three rows; the persons table (76 guests) is derived from it and carries only each guest's name and appearance count. Jurisdiction, party, inclusion category, and office held are recorded per appearance as of the air date, because they change over a guest's career. "Required" marks fields that may never be missing from any row of the table. Race type, office level, cycle, and party are free-text fields with no fixed vocabulary in the schema. The cycle label differs from the cycle in Table V.4, which assigns each appearance to the next federal general election after its air date. For 59 appearances, fields left blank at hand review were filled from the model's pre-coding proposals and then checked (Appendix A).

Appendix C. Event Windows and Full Regression Results

Table C.1 defines the event windows, Tables C.2 and C.3 report the full event-window estimates for full shows and for the pooled sample, Table C.4 reports the two illustrative windows, Table C.5 reports the format comparison, while Figures C.1 and C.2 plot the event-window and format estimates.

Table C.1. Event Window Definitions

Window	Start	End	Category
COVID onset	March 11, 2020	April 30, 2020	Other
George Floyd protests	May 25, 2020	July 31, 2020	Consensus shock
2020 presidential run-up	September 1, 2020	November 30, 2020	Consensus shock
Dobbs decision	June 24, 2022	August 31, 2022	Cross-cutting shock
2022 midterm run-up	September 1, 2022	November 30, 2022	Other
2024 presidential run-up	September 1, 2024	November 30, 2024	Consensus shock
DaBaby remarks at Rolling Loud	Four weeks, July 2021		Illustration

Window	Start	End	Category
Release of *The Closer*	Four weeks, October 2021		Illustration

Note: Windows were fixed before results were seen but were not formally pre-registered. Each window is compared with the rest of its own calendar year. The five main windows are estimated jointly; the two illustrative windows are added in a separate model and fall in 2021, a year with no other window, so they leave the main estimates unchanged. Categories follow the consensus and cross-cutting distinction in Section II.

Table C.2. Event-Window Estimates, Full Shows

Outcome	Window	Estimate (pp)	SE	p	Window chunks
Politics topic	Presidential run-ups (2020, 2024)	+8.88***	2.54	< .001	4,453
Politics topic	Floyd protests	+7.43	4.80	.122	780
Politics topic	COVID onset	-0.41	3.18	.898	833
Politics topic	*Dobbs* decision	-1.11	2.24	.619	1,438
Politics topic	2022 midterm run-up	-1.31	2.28	.565	2,211
Direct present	Presidential run-ups (2020, 2024)	+10.23***	2.63	< .001	4,453
Direct present	Floyd protests	+19.89**	6.15	.001	780
Direct present	COVID onset	-0.76	4.00	.849	833
Direct present	*Dobbs* decision	-0.51	3.00	.864	1,438
Direct present	2022 midterm run-up	+0.13	3.05	.967	2,211
Ambient present	Presidential run-ups (2020, 2024)	-1.59*	0.77	.040	4,453
Ambient present	Floyd protests	-1.01	1.44	.484	780
Ambient present	COVID onset	-6.55***	1.13	< .001	833
Ambient present	*Dobbs* decision	-0.29	1.28	.820	1,438
Ambient present	2022 midterm run-up	+0.61	1.11	.583	2,211
Ambient share of framed	Presidential run-ups (2020, 2024)	-9.30***	2.28	< .001	1,906
Ambient share of framed	Floyd protests	-12.20***	3.61	< .001	444
Ambient share of framed	COVID onset	-15.65***	3.69	< .001	256
Ambient share of framed	*Dobbs* decision	-0.19	4.53	.966	—
Ambient share of framed	2022 midterm run-up	+1.27	4.00	.751	686

Note: Full shows, 2019 to May 2026, 62,080 chunks, advertisement and undated chunks excluded. Each estimate is the difference in percentage points between chunks inside the window and chunks in the rest of the same calendar year, from a linear probability model estimating all five windows jointly with year fixed effects and standard errors clustered by episode. Ambient-share rows are estimated on 19,531 framed chunks, and their window counts are framed chunks; these are the estimates reported in Table VI.3. * p < .05, ** p < .01, *** p < .001.

Table C.3. Event-Window Estimates, Full Shows and Standalone Interviews Pooled

Outcome	Window	Estimate (pp)	SE	p
Politics topic	Presidential run-ups (2020, 2024)	+7.12***	2.05	< .001
Politics topic	Floyd protests	+8.90***	2.35	< .001
Politics topic	COVID onset	+1.16	2.11	.582
Politics topic	*Dobbs* decision	-1.16	2.21	.600
Politics topic	2022 midterm run-up	+0.12	2.15	.957
Direct present	Presidential run-ups (2020, 2024)	+8.09***	2.13	< .001
Direct present	Floyd protests	+19.49***	3.02	< .001
Direct present	COVID onset	-0.29	2.64	.914
Direct present	*Dobbs* decision	-1.94	2.68	.469
Direct present	2022 midterm run-up	+0.51	2.72	.852
Ambient present	Presidential run-ups (2020, 2024)	-1.40*	0.62	.024
Ambient present	Floyd protests	+2.31*	1.13	.041
Ambient present	COVID onset	-5.65***	0.90	< .001
Ambient present	*Dobbs* decision	-1.10	0.98	.259
Ambient present	2022 midterm run-up	-0.47	0.96	.627
Ambient share of framed	Presidential run-ups (2020, 2024)	-7.96***	1.89	< .001
Ambient share of framed	Floyd protests	-7.20**	2.29	.002
Ambient share of framed	COVID onset	-13.46***	2.68	< .001

Outcome	Window	Estimate (pp)	SE	p
Ambient share of framed	*Dobbs* decision	-0.68	3.80	.858
Ambient share of framed	2022 midterm run-up	-1.59	3.40	.639

Note: Full shows and standalone interviews, 2019 to May 2026, advertisement and undated chunks excluded. Estimates and standard errors are computed as in Table C.2, with a product-type fixed effect added. * p < .05, ** p < .01, *** p < .001.

Two entertainment-originated controversies involving sexuality were tested with four-week windows as illustrations of cross-cutting shocks that arrive as celebrity content, and Table C.4 reports them. In full shows, sexuality terms rose by 2.2 points after DaBaby's remarks at Rolling Loud in July 2021 (p < .01) and by 3.2 points after the release of Dave Chappelle's *The Closer* in October 2021 (p < .05), while direct framing did not move, at −0.3 and −4.4 points (both not significant). The Chappelle window lowered the politics-topic share by 7.1 points (p < .001), and the ambient share of framed content rose by 8.8 points for Chappelle, which is not distinguishable from zero on a small window (p = .24).

Table C.4. Estimates for Two Entertainment-Originated Controversies Involving Sexuality

Sample	Window	Outcome	Estimate (pp)	SE	p
Full shows	DaBaby remarks (July 2021)	Sexuality terms	+2.20**	0.83	.008
Full shows	DaBaby remarks (July 2021)	Politics topic	+0.01	2.40	.996
Full shows	DaBaby remarks (July 2021)	Celebrity topic	-0.30	1.78	.868
Full shows	DaBaby remarks (July 2021)	Direct present	-0.28	2.93	.923
Full shows	DaBaby remarks (July 2021)	Ambient present	-2.69	1.55	.082
Full shows	DaBaby remarks (July 2021)	Ambient share of framed	-5.64	4.17	.177
Full shows	*The Closer* release (October 2021)	Sexuality terms	+3.20*	1.63	.050
Full shows	*The Closer* release (October 2021)	Politics topic	-7.09***	1.99	< .001
Full shows	*The Closer* release (October 2021)	Celebrity topic	+3.50	2.75	.202
Full shows	*The Closer* release (October 2021)	Direct present	-4.43	3.60	.219
Full shows	*The Closer* release (October 2021)	Ambient present	+1.83	3.22	.571
Full shows	*The Closer* release (October 2021)	Ambient share of framed	+8.83	7.48	.238
Pooled	DaBaby remarks (July 2021)	Sexuality terms	+2.40*	0.98	.014
Pooled	DaBaby remarks (July 2021)	Politics topic	+1.61	2.01	.423
Pooled	DaBaby remarks (July 2021)	Celebrity topic	+0.65	1.67	.697
Pooled	DaBaby remarks (July 2021)	Direct present	+0.05	2.59	.986
Pooled	DaBaby remarks (July 2021)	Ambient present	-2.25	1.17	.055
Pooled	DaBaby remarks (July 2021)	Ambient share of framed	-5.10	3.14	.105
Pooled	*The Closer* release (October 2021)	Sexuality terms	+1.97	1.30	.129
Pooled	*The Closer* release (October 2021)	Politics topic	-4.71**	1.46	.001
Pooled	*The Closer* release (October 2021)	Celebrity topic	+4.24*	2.12	.045
Pooled	*The Closer* release (October 2021)	Direct present	-4.15	2.47	.093
Pooled	*The Closer* release (October 2021)	Ambient present	+2.13	1.64	.194
Pooled	*The Closer* release (October 2021)	Ambient share of framed	+9.20	4.90	.060

Note: Full shows, and full shows pooled with standalone interviews, 2019 to May 2026, advertisement and undated chunks excluded. Each estimate is the difference in percentage points between chunks in the four-week window and chunks in the rest of 2021, from a linear probability model including all seven windows with year fixed effects (and a product-type fixed effect in the pooled sample) and standard errors clustered by episode. The sexuality-terms outcome is the share of chunks containing a term from the sexuality keyword set. * p < .05, ** p < .01, *** p < .001.

Table C.5. Donkey of the Day Clips and Standalone Interviews Relative to Full Shows

Outcome	Specification	Format	Estimate	SE	p	N
Framing present (pp)	A: year FE	Donkey of the Day	+7.70***	1.18	< .001	107,722
Framing present (pp)	A: year FE	Standalone interview	-2.05*	0.88	.020	107,722

Outcome	Specification	Format	Estimate	SE	p	N
Framing present (pp)	B: + topic FE	Donkey of the Day	+1.27	0.77	.097	107,722
Framing present (pp)	B: + topic FE	Standalone interview	-0.02	0.45	.968	107,722
Framing present (pp)	C: + topic FE, crime and celebrity dropped	Donkey of the Day	+3.30***	0.80	< .001	82,923
Framing present (pp)	C: + topic FE, crime and celebrity dropped	Standalone interview	-0.53	0.45	.241	82,923
Ambient present (pp)	A: year FE	Donkey of the Day	+4.54***	0.62	< .001	107,722
Ambient present (pp)	A: year FE	Standalone interview	-0.15	0.30	.612	107,722
Ambient present (pp)	B: + topic FE	Donkey of the Day	+1.90**	0.58	.001	107,722
Ambient present (pp)	B: + topic FE	Standalone interview	+0.58*	0.28	.038	107,722
Ambient present (pp)	C: + topic FE, crime and celebrity dropped	Donkey of the Day	+3.07***	0.57	< .001	82,923
Ambient present (pp)	C: + topic FE, crime and celebrity dropped	Standalone interview	+0.49	0.27	.071	82,923
Ambient share of framed (pp)	A: year FE	Donkey of the Day	+6.43***	1.68	< .001	33,937
Ambient share of framed (pp)	A: year FE	Standalone interview	+1.33	1.07	.214	33,937
Ambient share of framed (pp)	B: + topic FE	Donkey of the Day	+3.97**	1.25	.001	33,937
Ambient share of framed (pp)	B: + topic FE	Standalone interview	+1.67*	0.66	.011	33,937
Ambient share of framed (pp)	C: + topic FE, crime and celebrity dropped	Donkey of the Day	+4.41***	1.31	< .001	27,068
Ambient share of framed (pp)	C: + topic FE, crime and celebrity dropped	Standalone interview	+2.22***	0.66	< .001	27,068
Mean ideology (scale points)	A: year FE	Donkey of the Day	-0.23***	0.04	< .001	33,606
Mean ideology (scale points)	A: year FE	Standalone interview	-0.03	0.04	.423	33,606
Mean ideology (scale points)	B: + topic FE	Donkey of the Day	-0.21***	0.04	< .001	33,606
Mean ideology (scale points)	B: + topic FE	Standalone interview	-0.03	0.04	.409	33,606
Mean ideology (scale points)	C: + topic FE, crime and celebrity dropped	Donkey of the Day	-0.27***	0.05	< .001	26,785
Mean ideology (scale points)	C: + topic FE, crime and celebrity dropped	Standalone interview	-0.01	0.05	.892	26,785

Note: Donkey of the Day clips, standalone interviews, and full shows, 2019 to May 2026, advertisement chunks excluded; standalone Donkey of the Day clips begin in 2022. Each estimate is the difference between the named format and full shows, in percentage points for the first three outcomes and in scale points on the seven-point ideology scale (1 strongly liberal, 7 strongly conservative). Specification A includes year fixed effects; B adds topic fixed effects; C adds topic fixed effects and drops the crime and policing and the celebrity and entertainment categories, where classifier false positives are concentrated. Standard errors are clustered by episode, and N is chunks for the first two outcomes, framed chunks for the ambient share, and scored chunks for ideology; these are the estimates reported in Table VI.4. * p < .05, ** p < .01, *** p < .001.

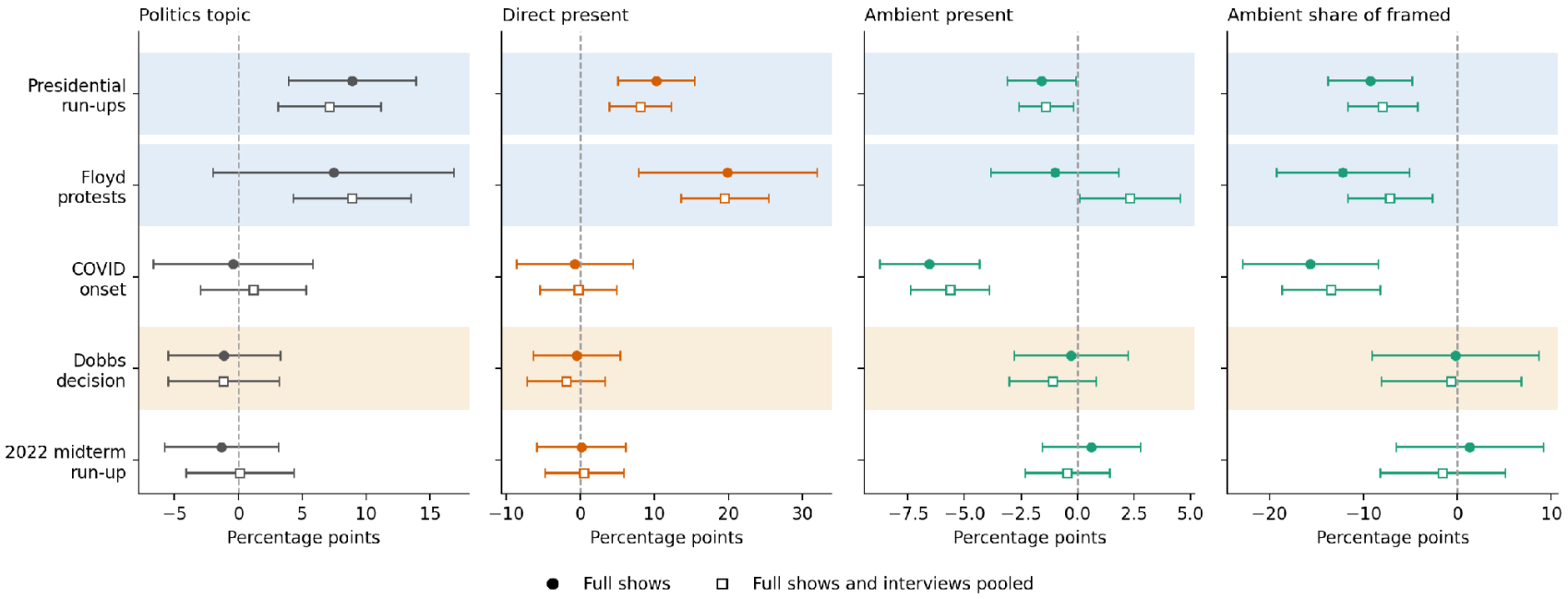


Figure C.1. Event-Window Estimates for Topic and Framing Outcomes.
Unit: Full shows, 2019 to May 2026 (filled markers), and full shows pooled with standalone interviews (open markers), advertisement chunks excluded. Each point is the difference in percentage points between chunks inside the window and chunks in the rest of the same calendar year, from linear probability models estimating all five windows jointly with year fixed effects (and a product-type fixed effect in the pooled sample); horizontal bars are 95 percent confidence intervals from standard errors clustered by episode. Colors mark the outcome: grey for the politics-topic share, orange for direct framing, and green for ambient framing and the ambient share of framed content. Rows shaded light blue are consensus shocks, the row shaded tan is the cross-cutting shock, and unshaded rows are other windows; the dashed vertical line marks zero.

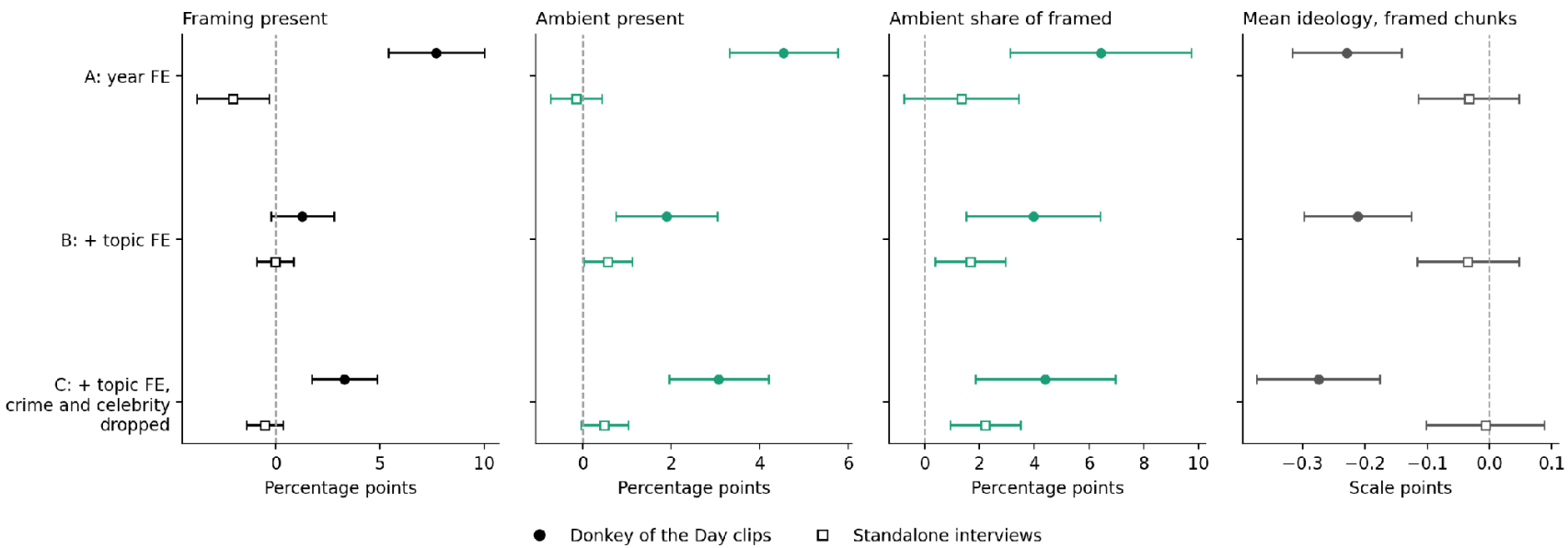


Figure C.2. Donkey of the Day Clips and Standalone Interviews Relative to Full Shows.
Unit: Donkey of the Day clips (filled markers) and standalone interviews (open markers) compared with full shows, 2019 to May 2026, advertisement chunks excluded. Each point is the estimated difference from full shows under one of three specifications (year fixed effects; adding topic fixed effects; adding topic fixed effects with the crime and celebrity categories dropped), in percentage points for the first three panels and in scale points on the seven-point ideology scale for the fourth; horizontal bars are 95 percent confidence intervals from standard errors clustered by episode. Green marks the ambient outcomes, and the dashed vertical line marks zero.

Appendix D. Supplementary Figures and Tables

Figure D.1 breaks direct and ambient framing down within each content type, and Table D.1 reports the year-level topic composition plotted in Figure VI.1.

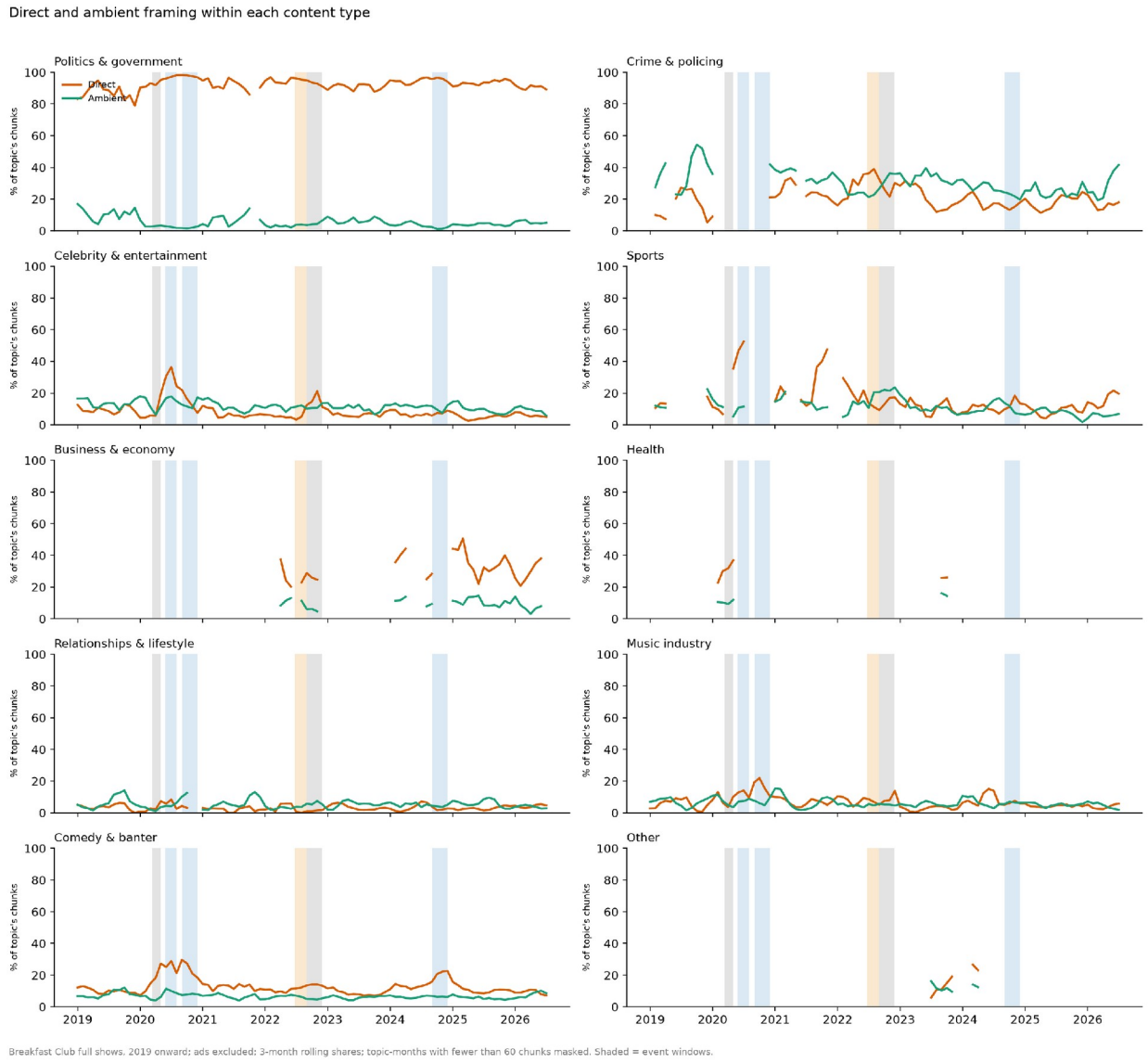


Figure D.1. Direct and Ambient Framing Within Each Content Type.
Unit: Full shows from 2019 to 2026, with advertisement chunks excluded. Each panel shows, for one primary topic, the share of that topic's chunks carrying direct framing (orange) and ambient framing (green) by month, as three-month centered rolling shares. Topic-months with fewer than 60 chunks are masked, which leaves gaps in the sparser topics, and shaded windows follow the scheme in Figure VI.4.

Table D.1. Topic Composition of Full Shows by Year

Year	Politics & govt	Crime & policing	Celebrity	Sports	Business	Health	Relationships	Music	Comedy & banter	Other	Full shows
2019	9.9	6.8	20.4	4.6	3.5	1.0	10.7	11.0	30.1	2.1	104
2020	19.3	4.9	15.0	6.1	2.0	5.3	8.3	13.0	24.5	1.6	87

Year	Politics & govt	Crime & policing	Celebrity	Sports	Business	Health	Relationships	Music	Comedy & banter	Other	Full shows
2021	10.5	8.1	17.8	5.6	4.2	3.0	10.6	12.9	25.7	1.7	102
2022	10.3	6.9	17.2	5.6	4.4	2.4	8.8	14.1	28.1	2.2	147
2023	10.4	7.2	16.3	4.3	1.9	1.4	10.6	12.5	32.2	3.1	181
2024	19.0	5.9	16.3	5.5	1.8	0.9	7.7	15.0	26.4	1.5	232
2025	16.5	6.8	17.9	5.7	2.7	1.0	7.9	14.4	25.7	1.4	233
2026 (to May)	14.1	4.8	16.6	7.1	2.7	1.6	10.0	15.6	26.2	1.3	125

Note: Full shows from 2019 to May 2026, where cells are percentages of non-advertisement runtime in each year, duration-weighted by chunk timestamps, and each row sums to approximately 100; the final column counts full-show episodes. The years 2016 to 2018, with 12, 6, and 27 full shows respectively, are omitted as too thin, and they run between 6 and 9 percent politics. Advertisement runtime, reported separately, is 5 to 13 percent of full-show runtime in every year through 2024 and falls to 6 percent in 2025 and under 1 percent in 2026, and the cause of that decline is not established in this paper. Figure VI.1 plots the same values.

Appendix E. Additional Transcript Examples

As mentioned in Section IV, the next two examples and boundary case below complete the set of transcript examples to illustrate the function of the classifier. The examples include ambient framing on a celebrity story, direct framing on a sports story, and a case the classifier correctly leaves uncoded; quotations are trimmed and corrected as described there.

Example 4. Ambient framing on a celebrity story. The example below comes from a full show on January 27, 2025, one week after the inauguration, when the subject was Snoop Dogg's response to criticism for performing at a Trump inaugural event. The hosts play his Instagram reply, in which he says "still a black man, still a hundred percent black," and then discuss it:

> "Snoop is so unbothered. […] The only thing I would just say, that people had an opinion. I wouldn't say that they were hating. — Nah, the people was mad. — Yeah, but that's not hate. They weren't hating on it. They had an opinion and they wanted, like, answers. Like, oh dang, but you said. — They were disappointed. — Yes, disappointment is better."

The exchange includes no political claim, since the segment is about a celebrity and what he may have owed his fans. However, it nonetheless presupposes that performing for Trump is a decision that requires an answer to Black audiences, and contextually situates the Black community's response as "disappointment". The exchange is a traditional example of Cohen's boundary work without a single explicitly political sentence (Cohen 1999). The classifier's rationale reads: *frames Snoop's performance as a politically charged decision that warranted public criticism and disappointment, invoking racialized identity as central to the controversy's significance without explicit policy commentary.* The chunk is coded as ambient, with an ideology score of 4.

Example 5. Direct framing on a sports story. The fifth example comes from a full show on May 23, 2022, after Nick Saban had criticized name, image, and likeness deals in college football, and Charlamagne responds:

> "This is long overdue and it's gonna make a lot of players very wealthy, and rightfully so. There's absolutely no reason for anyone to be against this, because NCAA college

> sports, especially in basketball and football, are multi-billion-dollar businesses, and historically everybody at these schools is reaping the benefits of the work these kids are putting in, except for the kids. […] Some of these kids come from conditions that aren't the best. […] Now you are providing them the opportunity to get their parents out the hood."

While sports is the primary topic and topic label, the framing involves a clearly stated policy position on compensation of college athletes, attached to an argument about distribution. A traditional content analysis counting politics by topic would miss this discussion about systemic equity.. The classifier's rationale reads: *explicitly advocates for NIL policy for college athletes, arguing it is "the right thing to do" and contrasts this position against Nick Saban's opposing view, directly engaging with a policy debate about compensation and systemic equity.* The chunk is coded as direct, with an ideology score of 3.

A boundary case. On a full show on June 6, 2024, Charlamagne gave Donkey of the Day to Corey Harris, whose viral court appearance while driving had been spun into a misinformation cycle. The segment is about a Black man in the court system and is delivered in Charlamagne's most editorial voice, yet the classifier coded it as carrying no political framing. The classifier's rationale reads: *casual radio discussion about a specific individual's driving record and legal situation that focuses on media misinformation and narrative-spinning, without commentary on policing practices, justice system policy, or racialized framing.* While the ultimate decision to exclude based on the full reading of the segment is supported, this case is included here because where a less careful coding might have deemed it political.